

Partisan Migration and Political Segregation

Stuart Gabriel* Benjamin Pirie† Gregor Schubert‡

June 25, 2025

Abstract

We show that partisan identity has become an increasingly important determinant of where Americans choose to live. Using individual-level voter-registration records for 2012-2022, we construct county-to-county migration flows by party and quantify the degree to which migration is “politically-aligned”—moving to a county whose presidential vote share matches one’s own party. We use this data to estimate party-specific location preferences in a spatial equilibrium model and find a sharp increase in partisan preferences: in 2020-2022 a 1 percent rise in a destination’s Democratic vote share raises Democratic in-migration by 1.8 percent and reduces Republican in-migration by 0.8 percent. This partisan preference by Democratic movers represents a 29% increase relative to 2012-2015, while Republican movers’ partisanship only increased in magnitude by 6%. This can explain the growth in county-level partisan segregation, as the share of counties that were similarly attractive to both parties declined substantially during the decade.

KEYWORDS: political sorting, migration, spatial equilibrium, homophily

JEL CLASSIFICATION: R13, R21, R23, D72

*UCLA, Anderson School of Management. Contact: stuart.gabriel@anderson.ucla.edu

†UCLA, Department of Economics. Contact: btpirie@outlook.com

‡UCLA, Anderson School of Management. Contact: gregor.schubert@anderson.ucla.edu

1 Introduction

In recent decades, both scholarly research and public discourse have intensified around the subject of political polarization in the United States. A recent Pew Research Center report highlights that the share of Democrats and Republicans with highly negative views of the opposing party has more than doubled between 1994 and 2014, from 16% to 38% for Democrats and 17% to 43% for Republicans ([Pew Research Center, 2014](#)). Academic research has shown that political polarization plays a role in wide array of economic and social domains, including media consumption, workplace sorting, and offline social interactions. Despite this growing evidence that polarization is increasingly shaping everyday behavior and identity, the extent to which Americans have sorted geographically along partisan lines remains unclear. In particular, whether politics have become an important factor in household location decisions—on par with economic variables like wages, housing costs, or amenities—remains an open question.

Understanding the geographic dimension of political polarization is important not only descriptively but also for its broader implications. From a normative perspective, increased partisan sorting across space may exacerbate political echo chambers and reduce exposure to diverse viewpoints, potentially undermining the foundations of democratic society ([Sunstein, 2001](#); [Bishop and Cushing, 2008](#)). Communities that are politically homogeneous may reinforce ideological extremity and reduce incentives for political moderation. From a positive perspective, political geography may also shape economic outcomes: there is evidence that politically competitive places are associated with higher economic productivity and innovation, potentially due to more contestable political institutions or diverse labor markets ([Besley et al., 2010](#); [Stansel, 2005](#); [Hatfield and Kosec, 2013](#)). These observations underscore the stakes in measuring and understanding the extent of political sorting across space.

This paper provides new evidence on the role of political alignment in shaping internal migration decisions in the United States. We define political alignment as migration into a destination where the average political views match that of the migrant. Using detailed

micro-data on inter-county migration and a structural model of location choice, we quantify the extent to which individuals sort geographically based on partisan preferences. Our approach integrates political alignment into a spatial equilibrium framework, allowing us to estimate its role relative to traditional drivers such as wages, housing costs, and climate. We use this to estimate party-specific preferences for political alignment with a destination county. We also estimate the extent to which political differences between origin and destination counties hinders migration. Our findings suggest that partisan identity is increasingly becoming a salient dimension of location choice in the contemporary U.S.

We use voter registration micro-data to compute aggregate county-to-county migration flows by political party. The registration data includes information on each registrant’s name, address, age, and political affiliation. We identify movers¹ and aggregate the data to a panel of party-level migration flows between every pair of counties. Our data includes all registered voters in the period 2012 through 2022. This time period allows us to observe changes in partisan migration trends before and after the first Trump term, something that has been discussed as a potentially pivotal point in US polarization.

We document new facts on the migration patterns of Republicans and Democrats from 2012 through 2022. Movers from the two parties have been on different trends in terms of partisan alignment with their destinations during the span of our data. Republicans have been increasingly likely to move to destinations that favor their political views, with a declining share of them moving from Republican leaning counties into Democratic ones. On the other hand, Democratic migration trends have been relatively stable². Although migration trends around 2020 are subject to influence of the COVID-19 pandemic, there are clear trends in party-specific migration that predate this period.

Migration trends suggest that there is increased sorting into politically aligned destinations by partisan movers. We show that the distributions of destination partisanship for

¹We use “mover” and “migrant” interchangeably to mean an individual who changes address in the voter registration data.

²We measure a county’s political affiliation in a given year using the democratic vote share from the previous presidential election. For more details on this, see Section 2.2.

Republican and Democratic movers are diverging, with a greater share of migrants moving into counties that align with their political views. We observe this trend over the whole period of study. These raw trends suggest that partisan sorting is occurring and has perhaps intensified over the last decade. However, these observed trends may reflect a combination of economic, demographic, and political factors.

To disentangle the role of political preferences from other determinants of migration, we develop a structural location choice model that incorporates preferences for partisanship. This model is founded in spatial equilibrium, where we add a preference term for being politically aligned with your destination to the standard model. This structure allows us to quantify the importance of political alignment relative to other more standard factors in the migration decision, such as prices, wages, and amenities.

We derive a gravity equation from the model and estimate it with our constructed panel of party-specific migration flows between all county-pairs in the US. We estimate the gravity equation in a two-step procedure. First, we recover destination-specific measures of attractiveness separately by party and time. Second, we show that the average attractiveness of a destination depends on its local partisanship and document how the relationship differs by political affiliation and over time. In addition, we provide evidence for how costly it is to migrate between politically dissimilar counties and compare this to the impact of physical and other cultural differences.

Our results suggest that Democratic and Republican migrants have strong preferences for destinations that align with their political views. We also find that partisanship was an increasingly influential factor in migration decisions from 2012 through 2022. In the first four years of our study, Democratic migrants preferred destinations with a higher Democratic vote share in the 2012 election. Republicans had an even stronger preference for destinations with a lower Democratic vote share. Over the rest of our study period, we find a steady increase in the alignment preference for Democratic movers, while the alignment preference for Republican movers held steady. This divergence has dramatically reduced the number

of destinations that are similarly attractive to migrants of both parties. As a result, these changing preferences have likely contributed to the geographic polarization of the electorate.

Our paper contributes to two distinct but increasingly intersecting literatures: the study of political polarization and the literature on the determinants of internal migration in the United States. While political polarization has been extensively examined in recent decades, its implications for migration choices remain less well understood. At the same time, economic models of internal migration, which emphasize wages, housing costs, and amenities as salient factors in household location decisions, have not typically considered the role of political alignment. By integrating political preferences into a spatial equilibrium framework, our paper helps bridge these two literatures and provides new evidence on the role of ideology in shaping locational decisions.

First, we contribute to the literature on political polarization by providing new evidence that counties are increasingly diverging in their attractiveness to migrants with different political affiliations. Research in this field has documented growing ideological and affective divides between Democrats and Republicans, with implications for media consumption (Iyengar and Hahn, 2009; Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011; Levendusky, 2013; Prior, 2007), workplace sorting (Chinoy and Koenen, 2024; Fos et al., 2022), and offline social interactions (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2011), including dating and family networks (Alford et al., 2011; Huber and Malhotra, 2017; Iyengar et al., 2018). The extent to which polarization has manifested in sorting across geographies is not yet well understood.

In this context, a longstanding hypothesis is that polarization may manifest geographically, as individuals “vote with their feet” and relocate to politically aligned communities (Tiebout, 1956; Bishop and Cushing, 2008). Recent empirical work has investigated this hypothesis with mixed results. Some studies find limited evidence of intentional partisan sorting (Abrams and Fiorina, 2012; Mummolo and Nall, 2017), while others document rising spatial segregation by party (Tam Cho et al., 2013; Johnston et al., 2016; Kinsella et al., 2015; Sussell, 2013; Myers, 2013). In the economics literature, Brown et al. (2025) use voter

registration data to show an increase in partisan residential segregation since 2008, but attribute much of this change to demographic replacement rather than migration. Similarly, [Cantoni and Pons \(2022\)](#) and [Brown et al. \(2023\)](#) highlight how location shapes political behavior, suggesting an important contextual effect of place. Our work complements and extends this literature by directly quantifying the extent to which partisan preferences affect migration decisions and by distinguishing these effects from demographic and economic covariates.

Second, we contribute to a well-established literature in urban and regional economics on the causes and consequences of internal migration. Foundational spatial equilibrium models ([Rosen, 1979](#); [Roback, 1982](#)) consider that individuals sort across locations, balancing wages, housing costs, and local amenities. A large empirical literature has extended these models to estimate the value of amenities (e.g., climate, crime, school quality) and the impact of housing supply frictions on labor market outcomes ([Glaeser and Gyourko, 2005](#); [Hsieh and Moretti, 2019](#)). Other papers show sorting based on migrant characteristics, for example migrant education ([Diamond, 2016](#)). While these frameworks allow for heterogeneous preferences, with researchers often considering differences across skill- or education-levels, they have not yet been adapted to incorporate heterogeneous preferences by political affiliation. Our paper extends the standard spatial equilibrium model by introducing a taste parameter for political alignment, which we then estimate using migration data for registered voters. This allows us to assess whether political compatibility plays an important role in one’s residential location decision.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the data and Section 3 presents several novel descriptive trends. Section 4 outlines the model and estimation strategy, Section 5 reports results, and Section 6 discusses implications for geographic political polarization. Section 7 concludes.

2 Data

To understand whether political alignment influences migration choices, we need measures of political beliefs for migrants and for locations. We use voter registration data from all 50 states, plus Washington DC over the years 2012 through 2022 to track migration of partisan affiliated voters. To measure local partisanship, we use county-level presidential vote shares. We supplement this data with information on county-level amenities, prices, wages, and other characteristics that are known to influence migration³.

2.1 Voter Registration Data

We use data on the universe of registered US voters from 2012 through 2022. The data is provided by Statara, a data vendor that collects publicly available voter registration information and compiles it into a single usable dataset. This registration data lends itself well to answering our research question because it contains individual level information on addresses and political affiliation. The data also includes date of birth, as well as several demographic variables that Statara has added by linking people to datasets provided by other vendors.

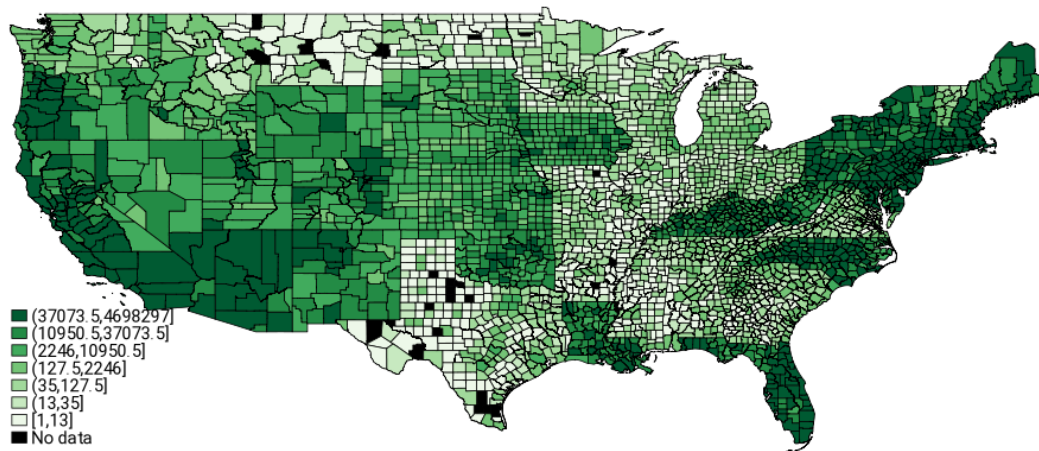
We track registered voters over time and identify changes in address to measure migration. In the registration process, voters are given a unique voter identification number, which they keep even after updating their address to a new location, as long as it is within the same state. Since voter registration is a state-managed process, voters who move across state lines are given a new identification number when they re-register. We therefore use Statara’s person-level identifier that tracks people over time, even across inter-state moves. We then identify movers using changes in address listed on their voter registration. Lastly, we collapse our data into three periods, computing total migration in 2012-2015, 2016-2019, and 2020-2022⁴.

Important for answering how political alignment influences migration choices is the fact that the voter registration dataset includes party preferences of registered voters. In most

³For a full description of this supplemental data, see Appendix C.

⁴See Appendix D for a description of the data cleaning steps and our algorithm for identifying moves.

Figure 1: Number of Party-Affiliated Migrants by Destination County



Notes: This figure shows the number of migrants into each county during the period 2012 through 2015. We measure migration using changes in address on voter registration data. Therefore, we only capture within US migration of registered voters. The counties are colored based on the number of migrants who are affiliated with a political party on their voter registration. There are 20 states in which both major parties use an open primary or caucus to nominate their presidential candidate. In these states, registering voters do not list a party affiliation. As a result, most party-affiliated migrants into counties within these states originate from one of the other 30 states. The full list of open primary states is AL, AR, GA, HI, IL, IN, MI, MN, MO, MS, MT, ND, OH, SC, TN, TX, VA, VT, WA, and WI.

states, individuals registering to vote are prompted to list a party affiliation. Doing so allows them to participate in their party's primary or caucus – the process for nominating a party's presidential candidate. In 20 states, both parties have open primaries, meaning that anyone can participate, regardless of party affiliation. Therefore, in these states registering voters are not prompted to indicate a party affiliation⁵. In the Appendix, Figure A-1 shows the counties in which at least one third of registered voters are affiliated with a political party.

We observe party-affiliated migrants moving into nearly every US county. Figure 1 shows the number of party-affiliated movers during 2012 through 2015 into each county within the contiguous 48 states, plus Washington DC. The figure reflects that there are a larger number of migrants into major metropolitan areas on the West Coast, North-East, and in the Sun Belt. The lower number of migrants in several Midwestern and Southern states is due to the fact that these are open primary states and registering voters in these states are not asked

⁵These states are AL, AR, GA, HI, IL, IN, MI, MN, MO, MS, MT, ND, OH, SC, TN, TX, VA, VT, WA, and WI.

to list a party affiliation. Therefore, the number of party-affiliated migrants into counties within these states is restricted to movers who originate in other states.

Given that our data represents registered voters, our findings speak to migration for just this subset of the population. We characterize this population in Table 1, which summarizes individual characteristics in the Statara data. The Mover and Party Switcher variables indicate behavior over the next four years – they take a value of 1 if a person’s address or political affiliation change between 2016 and 2012, respectively. Age and party affiliation comes directly from the voter registration files. The average person in our data is 50 years old, reflecting that older Americans are more likely to be registered voters. Overall there is a larger share of voters registered with the Democratic party than the Republican party⁶, though the majority of voters fall into the *Other* category, which is primarily composed of voters with no party affiliation. The additional demographic characteristics are added by Statara, who link registered voters to data from other vendors⁷. While the sample is not necessarily representative of the overall US population, it likely captures the set of individuals who are most politically engaged.

In Table 2, we examine how voters characteristics differ by party affiliation and by mover status. The results suggest that Republicans move more frequently than Democrats and that Democrats are more likely to switch their party affiliation than Republicans. The other results align with our expectations. Democrats tend to be younger and are more likely to be female, single, and non-white. Movers tend also to be younger and more likely to be single. However, movers are more likely to be white.

We aggregate the universe of voter registration data into a panel of party-specific migra-

⁶We categorize voters who are affiliated with either the Democratic Party, the Green Party, or the Working Families Party to as Democrats. We categorize voters who are affiliated with either the Republican Party or the Conservative Party as Republicans.

⁷While Statara’s primary data source is voter registration files, they link the registration records to data from other vendors to get these additional variables. Sometimes these additional data sources include individuals who cannot be matched to registered voters, in which case they are listed as “Unregistered”. Table 1 shows that these individuals make up nearly a third of the sample. Going forward, we drop all “Unregistered” observations from our analysis.

Table 1: Average Statara Demographics

	Mean	SD
Mover	0.063	0.244
Party Switcher	0.036	0.187
Age	50.040	18.586
Female	0.501	0.500
Non-Married	0.414	0.493
White	0.584	0.493
Reg. Republican	0.120	0.325
Reg. Democrat	0.166	0.372
Reg. Other	0.421	0.494
Unregistered	0.292	0.455
Observations	2,483,745	

Notes: This table summarizes the characteristics of voters in the registration data from Statara. Due to the size of the data, the summary statistics are for a random 1% sample of registered voters in 2012. We construct the *Mover* and *Party Switcher* variables by comparing individuals' linked voter registration information over time. *Mover* is the share of voters who will move within 4 years. Similarly, *Party Switcher* is the share of voters who will change their party affiliation within 4 years. We consider a switch of affiliation to be movements between Republican, Democrat, or Other/Unaffiliated. Gender, marital status, and race are variables provided by Statara, who matches voter records with data from other vendors. Party affiliation, registration status, and date of birth come directly from the voter registration files provided by Statara.

Table 2: Average Statara Demographics, Split by Characteristics

	By Party			By Mover Status		
	Republican	Democrat	Diff.	Non-Mover	Mover	Diff.
Mover	0.064	0.055	0.009***			
Party Switcher	0.046	0.049	-0.003***	0.029	0.143	-0.114***
Age	52.003	50.675	1.328***	52.983	49.641	3.342***
Female	0.488	0.554	-0.066***	0.503	0.502	0.001
Non-Married	0.446	0.588	-0.142***	0.402	0.477	-0.075***
White	0.879	0.653	0.225***	0.629	0.754	-0.125***
Reg. Republican				0.139	0.140	-0.001
Reg. Democrat				0.184	0.157	0.027***
Reg. Other				0.448	0.460	-0.012***
Unregistered				0.229	0.243	-0.014***
Observations	297,517	413,302	710,819	1,449,745	98,280	1,548,025

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: This table summarizes the characteristics of voters in the registration data from Statara, broken down by mover status and party affiliation. Due to the size of the data, the summary statistics are for a random 1% sample of registered voters in 2012. In the first set of columns we further restrict this sample to registered voters who are affiliated with the Democratic, Green, and Working Families Parties, all grouped into “Democrat”, or those affiliated with the Republican and the Conservative Parties, grouped into “Republican”. The sample in the second set of columns includes all individuals from the random 1% sample, regardless of registration status or party affiliation. For this table, we construct the “Mover” and “Party Switcher” variables by comparing individuals’ linked voter registration information over time. “Mover” is the share of voters who will move within 4 years. Similarly, “Party Switcher” is the share of voters who will change their party affiliation within 4 years. We consider a switch of affiliation to be movements between Republican, Democrat, or Other/Unaffiliated. Gender, marital status, and race are variables provided by Statara, who matches voter records with data from other vendors. Party affiliation, registration status, and date of birth come directly from the voter registration files provided by Statara.

tion flows between each pair of counties for use in our main analysis⁸. We do not consider heterogeneity of preferences across the other demographic dimensions in our model, though future work could perhaps incorporate these characteristics. We summarize trends in the migration flows in Section 3 below.

2.2 Presidential Vote Shares

To measure local partisanship we use county-level vote share from presidential elections. While there has been extensive discussion in the political science literature about the right measure for local partisanship, we land on this measure due to the regularity of observations over time and comparability across all counties. One critique of this measure is that presidential vote shares may differ substantially from local political dynamics. However, as discussed in [Hopkins \(2018\)](#), there has been a recent convergence in national and local politics, with voters increasingly engaging at the national level, rather than local levels. Furthermore, presidential elections generate the highest turnout, particularly in recent periods, and are held consistently across the country. Therefore they provide a periodic measure of county-level political preferences, with a large set of voters choosing among the same set of options. Since we are considering nationwide migration choices over time, these characteristics make this an appropriate measure.

We use county-level vote share data from the [MIT Election Data and Science Lab \(2018\)](#). This dataset was updated most recently in 2021 to include the results of the 2020 presidential election. We restrict our attention to the 2012, 2016, and 2020 presidential elections to match the time period of our voter registration data. Our measure for each county’s partisanship is computed as the share of votes cast for the Democratic candidate (“Democratic vote share”). We use only the total number of votes for the Democratic or Republican candidates when computing each county’s Democratic vote share, ignoring any votes for the Green Party, Libertarian Party, or other parties.

⁸For a full description of the data processing steps to create this panel, see Appendix D.

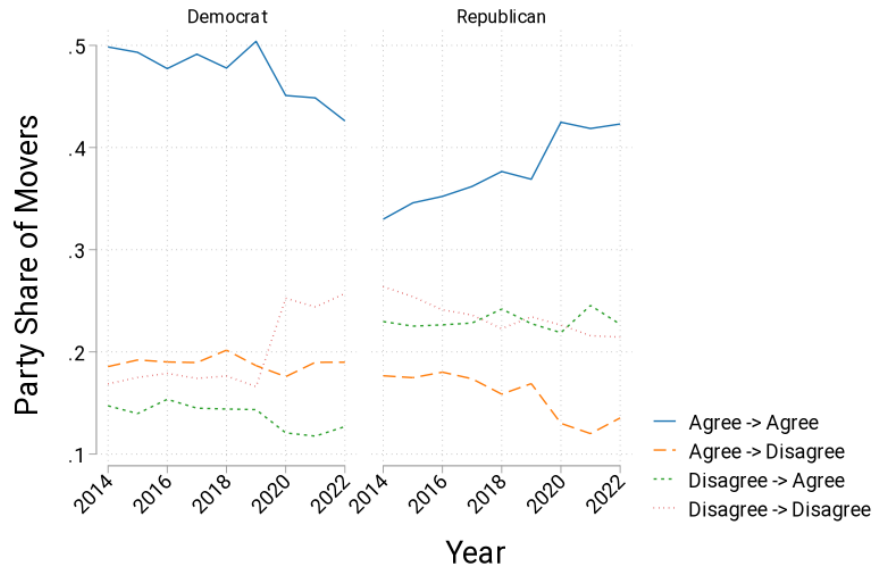
3 Partisan Migration Patterns

Before introducing our spatial model, we start by discussing raw migration trends from our voter registration data to provide suggestive evidence that political alignment matters to movers. We collapse the data into panel of party-specific inter-county migration flows and merge in the county-level democratic vote shares.

We start by documenting that migrants typically move to and from counties where the average political preferences match their own. Figure 2 plots the raw trends in party-specific migration, split by partisan agreement with the movers' origin and destination counties. The figure shows that roughly half of all Democrat migration is between Democratic leaning counties, with a slight decline starting in 2020, attributed to an increase in migration between Republican leaning counties. The share of Democrats moving between two counties with differing partisanship is roughly one third. On the other hand, Republicans have been increasingly likely to move to destinations that favor their political views. Over this period, the share of Republican movers that moved from Republican to Democratic leaning counties has nearly halved. This decline is more than accounted for by an increase in the share of Republican movers moving Republican leaning counties from Republican leaning counties.

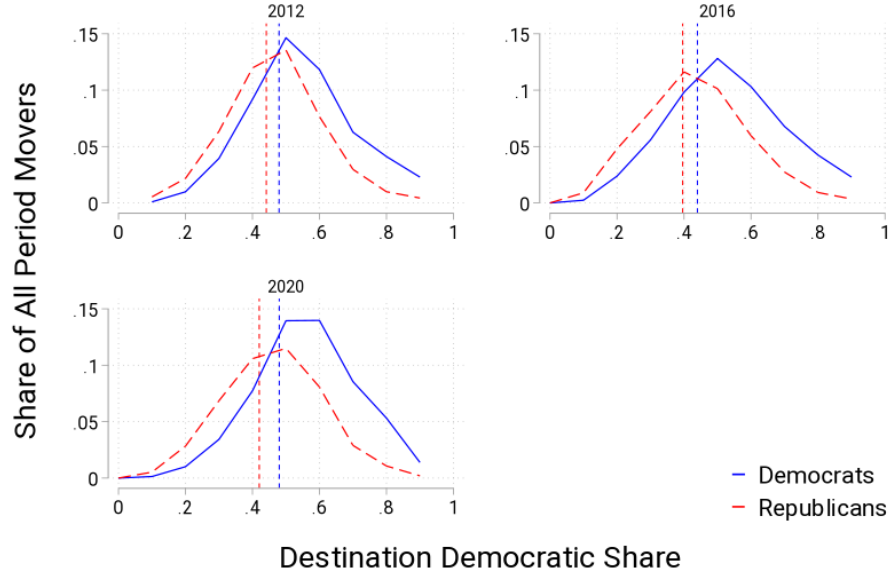
The next two figures investigate party migration trends with more detailed destination partisanship measures. Specifically, we now look at migration into destinations based on the Democratic vote share in the prior presidential election, rounded down to the nearest 10 percent. Figure 3 plots a smoothed distribution of the democratic vote share of destinations for all movers in each period, split by party. The figure shows that in every period there is a larger mass of Democrat movers moving to Democratic-leaning counties (those with Democratic vote share greater than 0.5), and a larger mass of Republican movers moving to Republican-leaning counties (those with Democratic vote share less than 0.5). Over time, the difference in these party-specific distributions seems to spread apart slightly. We plot the average destination Democratic vote share for movers from each party in every period, indicated by the vertical lines. The difference between these party averages increases by

Figure 2: Share of Party Movers by Agreement with Origin and Destination



Notes: This figure shows party-level migration trends for political alignment with origins and destinations. Specifically each panel shows the annual share of movers from each party, by their alignment with the partisanship of their origin and destination. We identify movers and their political affiliation with the Statara voter registration data, and we assign counties to be Democratic-leaning or Republican-leaning in any given year based on the local Democratic vote share from the previous presidential election. For both parties, the largest share of movers migrate between counties that both align with their political views. Republicans appear to be doing so at an increasing rate, with a decreasing share of Republicans moving from counties that align with their views to counties that do not. Roughly half of all Democratic movers migrate between two Democratic-leaning counties, though since 2020 there has been an increasing share of Democratic moves have been from those moving between Republican-leaning counties.

Figure 3: Distribution of Party Movers by the Destination's Democratic Share

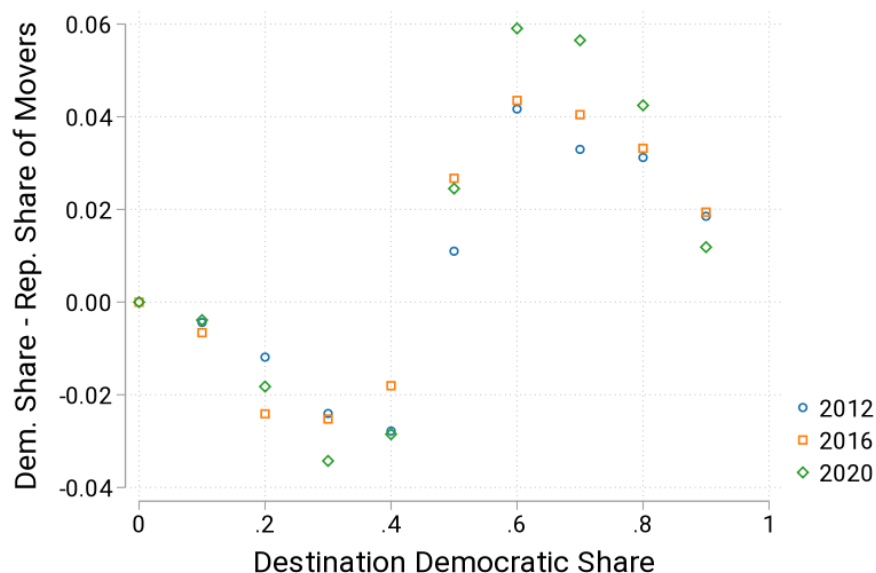


Notes: This figure shows the smoothed distribution of movers in a given period by party affiliation and the destination's Democratic vote share of the most recent presidential election. Each panel considers moves by party-affiliated voters during a four year period that starts with the indicated year. To construct the plot in each panel we compute the share of all movers in this period by party affiliation and destination democratic vote share, rounded down to the nearest 10 percent. We draw lines through these shares to trace out the distributions. In each panel, the areas under the Democrat and Republican curves together sum approximately to 1. We also plot the mean democratic vote shares of destinations for Republican movers and Democrat movers. The difference in these means was 3.81 percentage points in the 2012 period, 4.4 percentage points in the 2016 period, and 6.0 percentage points in the 2020 period.

more than 50 percent between the first and last period, from 3.81 percentage points to 6.0 percentage points.

Figure 4 provides another view of party-specific migration to destinations with differing Democratic vote shares. Here, we plot the percentage point difference between parties in their share of all movers who migrate into counties with a given binned Democratic vote share. The figure shows how these differences have changed over the three periods. We find that there are large increases in the relative share of Democrat movers into destinations with Democratic vote shares in the range of $[0.5, 0.9)$. Simultaneously, we see large decreases in the relative share of Democrat movers into destinations with Democratic vote shares in the range of $[0.2, 0.4)$. Figure A-2 in the Appendix provides yet another way of viewing these

Figure 4: Difference in the Party Share of Annual Movers



Notes: This figure shows the percentage point difference in the annual shares of Democratic and Republican voters moving to destinations with different partisanship. To compute each point we take the number of Democratic movers in a 4-year period to destinations with a particular democratic vote share (binned into 10 p.p. increments) and subtract the number of Republican movers in the same period to the same set of destinations. We then divide this difference by the total number of party-affiliated movers in that 4-year period. As an example of interpretation, consider the green diamond at 0.6 Destination Democratic Share. This point tells us that movers in 2020 were nearly 6 p.p. more likely to be Democrats moving to destinations with Democratic vote shares in the range of [60%,70%) than to be Republicans moving to destinations with the same range of Democratic vote shares. Between the periods following 2012 and 2020 party-affiliated movers to Democratic-leaning destinations are increasingly likely to be Democrats, while those movers to Republican-leaning destinations are increasingly likely to be Republicans.

changes over time.

Together, these trends in the raw data suggest that partisan alignment with a destination matters for movers and that the extent to which it matters has increased over the period of 2012 through 2022. However, these patterns reflect the myriad of other factors that influence migration decisions, including prices, wages, and amenities. If any of these factors, whose influence on migration is more well understood, correlated with local partisanship, then the presented relationships may be confounded by these other factors. In the following section, we outline a spatial equilibrium model that provides us some structure to isolate the effect

of destination partisanship alignment on migration choices by Democrats and Republicans.

4 Spatial Model

The approach of this paper is founded in spatial equilibrium. We propose a model that integrates political alignment into workers' location choices, allowing us to analyze how political preferences interact with economic factors and migration costs. From this model, we derive a simple gravity equation from which we can estimate preferences for political alignment with a destination.

4.1 Model Setup

We consider a discrete choice framework where workers in a particular origin county choose among multiple potential destination counties to maximize their utility. The utility function incorporates observable utility (which captures wages, house prices, and other amenities), political alignment, and migration costs that can vary by county pair, along with idiosyncratic preference shocks.

The utility that worker n of political affiliation $p \in \{\text{Democrat}, \text{Republican}\}$ derives from moving from origin i to potential destination j is:

$$U_{n,i \rightarrow j}^p = V_{i \rightarrow j}^p \cdot \varepsilon_{n,i \rightarrow j}^p \quad (1)$$

where $V_{i \rightarrow j}^p$ is the systematic utility component, and $\varepsilon_{n,i \rightarrow j}^p$ is an idiosyncratic shock, following a Fréchet distribution with cumulative distribution function $F(\varepsilon^p) = \exp(-\varepsilon^{-\theta})$, where a higher value of θ indicates lower dispersion in the idiosyncratic preference shocks and thus a greater importance for the systematic components of utility.

The systematic utility component $V_{i \rightarrow j}^p$ is specified as:

$$V_{i \rightarrow j}^p = w_j \cdot \exp(\delta^p \cdot \text{Alignment}_j^p - \tau_{i \rightarrow j}) \quad (2)$$

where w_j is the real wage in destination j , which is assumed to include the cost of housing and the value of local amenities. We later decompose this term. Alignment_j^p measures the political alignment between location j and movers of political affiliation p , with a parameter δ^p that captures the importance of political alignment in utility. This is our key parameter of interest. Note that we allow for heterogeneity in this alignment preference by party – political homophily does not have to be symmetric.

Furthermore, $\tau_{i \rightarrow j}$ represents the migration cost in utility units of moving from i to j ⁹. Note that the fact that this migration cost can vary across locations allows the model to generate empirically plausible migration networks, where moves from one location to another are more likely between particular origin-destination pairs. These migration costs can include, for example, physical distance, economic expenses, cultural differences, and policy barriers, and are a “sunk cost” once a move has been executed, such that we do not need to keep track of the full history of a worker’s past moves. We explore the role of political differences between pairs of counties on the flow of migration between them in Section 5.1.

4.2 Deriving the Gravity Equation

This model implies a gravity equation that relates migration flows to real wages, political alignment, and migration costs. The share of workers of political affiliation p that moves from i to j is:

$$\mu_{j|i}^p = \frac{[w_j \cdot \exp(\delta^p \cdot \text{Alignment}_j^p - \tau_{i \rightarrow j})]^\theta}{\sum_{k \in J} [w_k \cdot \exp(\delta^p \cdot \text{Alignment}_k^p - \tau_{i \rightarrow k})]^\theta} \quad (3)$$

where J is the set of all possible destinations. Total migration flows $M_{i \rightarrow j}^p$ from i to j by type p workers are then given by

$$M_{i \rightarrow j}^p = M_i^p \cdot \mu_{j|i}^p,$$

⁹We do not allow these costs to vary by party due to estimation limitations. Instead, we will let it vary over time to see if there have been changes in how differences in democratic share have affected the “cost” of moving between places

where M_i^p is the total number of workers with political affiliation p in origin i . Taking the natural logarithm of $M_{i \rightarrow j}^p$:

$$\ln M_{i \rightarrow j}^p = \ln M_i^p + \theta \ln w_j + \theta \delta^p \cdot \text{Alignment}_j^p - \theta \tau_{i \rightarrow j} - \ln D_i^p$$

where $D_i^p = \sum_{k \in J} [w_k \cdot \exp(\delta^p \cdot \text{Alignment}_k^p - \tau_{i \rightarrow k})]^\theta$. Going forward, we set $\theta = 1$ for simplicity.

4.3 Estimation Strategy

The key parameter of interest is δ^p , which captures party-specific preferences over partisan alignment with a destination. We estimate the model parameters using the implied gravity equation. Specifically, we perform the following two-step estimation procedure. First, we estimate the following regression equation

$$\ln M_{i \rightarrow j}^p = \alpha_i^p + \alpha_j^p + \gamma_{i,j} + \epsilon_{i \rightarrow j}^p \quad (4)$$

where $\alpha_i^p = \ln M_i^p - \ln D_i^p$, $\alpha_j^p = \ln w_j + \delta^p \cdot \text{Alignment}_j^p$, and $\gamma_{i,j} = -\tau_{i \rightarrow j}$.

Here, $M_{i \rightarrow j}^p$ measures the number of voters registered with party p who move from county i to county j . α_i^p (and α_j^p) are origin (and destination) by party fixed effects, which measure the average attractiveness of origin i (and destination j) to movers affiliated with party p . $\gamma_{i,j}$ is an origin by destination fixed effect, which captures the migration costs between counties i and j . $\epsilon_{i,j,t}^p$ is a residual term.

In the second step of our estimation procedure, we estimate the role of political alignment in determining a destination county's attractiveness to movers from each party, α_j^p . The model implies that a county's attractiveness as a destination is a function of real wages and preferences over political alignment. We therefore estimate the following regression equation,

$$\alpha_j^p = \beta_0 + \beta_1 w_j + \beta_2 \text{Alignment}_j^p + \epsilon_j^p \quad (5)$$

where β_2 recovers δ^p and w_j represents a set of variables that capture other components of a destination's attractiveness, including prices, amenities, and wages. ϵ_j^p is a residual term. We describe our specific measures for these terms along with our results in Section 5.

4.4 Identification issues

There are a number of issues with simply estimating Equation 5 as is. On the one hand, there are potential measurement issues for the included variables. For example, we may not have sufficient data to capture the true attractiveness of a location, w_j . There may be unobserved amenities that drive migration flows and would bias the estimated coefficients. Moreover, alignment, as well as other characteristics on the right-hand side, may be subject to reverse causality with respect to migration flows. We can address many of these concerns by leveraging the time component of our data to control for time-invariant components of a destination's attractiveness. We augment Equations 4 and 5 by adding time subscripts to both and destination fixed effects to the latter:

$$\ln M_{i \rightarrow j, t}^p = \alpha_{i, t}^p + \alpha_{j, t}^p + \gamma_{ij, t} + \epsilon_{i \rightarrow j, t}^p \quad (6)$$

$$\alpha_{j, t}^p = \psi_j + \beta_1 \tilde{w}_{j, t} + \beta_2 \text{Alignment}_{j, t}^p + \epsilon_{j, t}^p \quad (7)$$

Here, ψ_j is a destination fixed effect that captures all time-invariant components of j 's attractiveness and $\tilde{w}_{j, t}$ is the remaining time varying component, which might include prices, wages, and endogenous amenities¹⁰. The remaining parameters are as described in the previous subsection, though now specific to period t . In our estimation, we will divide our data into three periods, aligning with presidential elections: 2012-2015, 2016-2019, and 2020-2022.

In order to obtain accurate coefficients on the $\text{Alignment}_{j, t}^p$ term we still need to address

¹⁰In particular, endogenous amenities refer to the availability of retail, service, and other types of establishments that (Almagro and Domínguez-Iino, 2024).

the possibility that the real wage terms are changing endogenously, e.g. as a function of the migration flows. We can address this issue by finding suitable instruments for real wages. We use a Bartik wage shift share shock as an instrument for nominal wages, and interact it with local land supply constraints to obtain variation in housing costs. We can then estimate β_2 from Equation 7 with data on endogenous amenities, wages, and prices for $\tilde{w}_{j,t}$. We instrument for the latter two with the Bartik instruments¹¹.

We include one additional model as a robustness check, which uses $\alpha_{j,t}^{Dem} - \alpha_{j,t}^{Rep}$ as the independent variable. This differencing should control for all destination by period factors that are not differentially important to Democratic and Republican migrants. This exercise is conducted in Appendix F.

5 Estimation and Results

We estimate several reduced-form Equations implied by the model in Section 4 to examine the role of partisanship on migration choices. First, we provide evidence that differences in local partisanship represent a “cost” of migrating between counties. Second, as described in Section 4.3, we estimate preferences for political alignment separately for Democratic and Republican movers, finding that movers from both parties prefer destinations that align with their political views. We additionally show that the influence of partisanship in migration decisions increased over the study period.

Before we can estimate the role of partisanship on migration costs or preferences for destination alignment we must first recover estimates of the fixed effects in Equation 6. We estimate this reduced-form gravity equation using poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood regression with multiple levels of fixed effects¹² and our panel of county-to-county migration flows by party.

¹¹We do not instrument for endogenous amenities and instead assume that amenities are not responding to migration patterns at a rate that is consequential for the time duration that we study. Future work could relax this assumption with additional instruments.

¹²Specifically, we use the PPMLHDFE model developed for Stata by [Correia et al. \(2020\)](#).

In the following subsections we separately explore the estimated fixed effects, $\gamma_{ij,t}$ and $\alpha_{j,t}^p$, which capture the migration costs in period t of moving between i and j , and the party specific attractiveness of destination j in period t , respectively.

5.1 Migration Costs

We decompose the migration cost parameter from Equation 6 to understand how partisan differences between pairs of counties influences the cost of migrating between them. Even after controlling for various factors that are known to influence migration, we find that moving between counties with greater differences in partisanship imposes a greater cost on migrants.

To understand the influence of partisan differences on migration costs, we regress our estimates of the $\gamma_{ij,t}$ parameters onto physical distance as well as cultural, ethnic, economic, and political differences between counties i and j during period t . In Equation 6, $\gamma_{ij,t}$ captures the average bilateral cost of migrating between counties i and j during election period t . By regressing our estimates of this parameter onto political differences between counties i and j , we can provide insight into the costs of moving between politically dissimilar counties. We additionally control for additional distance and difference variables that capture known costs to migration. Specifically, we estimate the following regression

$$\gamma_{ij,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 |\text{Dem. Share}_{i,t} - \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t}| + \alpha_2 |\mathbf{X}_{i,t} - \mathbf{X}_{j,t}| + \beta_3 |\mathbf{X}_i - \mathbf{X}_j| + \varepsilon_{ij,t} \quad (8)$$

where $|\mathbf{X}_{i,t} - \mathbf{X}_{j,t}|$ is a set of differences in time-varying characteristics and $|\mathbf{X}_i - \mathbf{X}_j|$ is a set differences in time-invariant characteristics between counties i and j . These variables include local amenities, weather, industrial composition, culture and ethnic composition, as well as measures of physical distance, among other things¹³. β_1 captures the role of political differences on the bilateral cost of moving between counties i and j . We measure political

¹³See Appendix C for a full description of these control variables and their construction.

differences as the absolute difference in the Democratic share of votes in counties i and j from the presidential election at the beginning of period t .

Table 3: Influence of Partisan Differences on Moving Costs

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Dem. Vote Share Diff.	-2.764*** (0.006)	-1.200*** (0.006)	-0.549*** (0.014)
2016 $\times$ Dem. Vote Share Diff.			-0.607*** (0.018)
2020 $\times$ Dem. Vote Share Diff.			-0.686*** (0.018)
Controls	No	Yes	Yes
R-Squared	0.054	0.310	0.329
Observations	3,376,124	3,376,124	3,376,124

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: This table reports the coefficients of interest from estimating Equation 8 with OLS on our panel county-to-county migration flows of Democrats and Republicans. Columns (1) and (2) report the results from pooling all election periods, while Column (3) reports the results from a version of the model that allows all parameters to vary flexibly by period. Column (1) does not include additional controls, while Column (2) includes the full set of controls, described in Appendix C. The coefficients from Column (3) come from estimating Equation 8 after interacting every independent variable with the election period. Therefore, not only are the effects of Democratic Vote Share allowed to differ by election period, but so are the effects of all other controls. To see the estimated coefficients on the full set of controls, see Table B-1 in Appendix B.

Table 3 shows our estimated coefficients of interest from Equation 8, with negative coefficients implying that a greater difference imposes a greater cost of migration. Column (2) estimates the model as written, while Column (1) excludes the additional controls and Column (3) allows all parameters to vary flexibly by period¹⁴. We can see from the results that greater differences in the Democratic vote share of a pair of counties implies a greater cost of migrating between them. The smaller magnitude of the estimate in Column (2) compared to Column (1) suggests that differences in Democratic vote share are correlated with at least

¹⁴The coefficients in Column (3) are from estimating a version of Equation 8 where we allow the right hand side to vary flexibly by period. Specifically we interact each of the independent variables with period dummies (2016 indicates the period 2016-2019 and 2020 indicates the period 2020-2022. The term with no period interaction is interpreted as the effect in 2012-2015). For the full specification written out, see Appendix E.1.

some of the additional controls. Appendix Table B-1 reports the coefficients for all other factors included as controls when estimating Equation 8. To put the estimated Democratic vote share coefficients into context, we can compare them to the coefficient on differences in the population shares of college graduates. Diamond (2016) shows that college education is an important dimension by which people have sorted geographically. The results in Table B-1 suggest that differences in the Democratic vote share impose roughly half the cost to migration as differences in the population share of college graduates.

Column (3) of Table 3 shows that the cost of migrating between counties with differences in their Democratic vote share has dramatically increased over time. The effect of differences in the Democratic vote share in the period that begins in 2012 is given by the coefficient in the first row. The total effect of these differences in the period that begins in 2016, given by the sum of the coefficients in the first and second row, is more than twice the effect in the 2012 period. This increase persists into the period beginning in 2020, in which the total effect is given by summing the coefficients in the first and third rows.

We conclude from these results that differences in county partisanship impose a significant cost to migration. Namely, people prefer to move between counties that are politically similar to one another. To put these results into context, we find that the role of partisan differences is roughly half that of differences in the population share of college graduates. We also find that the role of partisan differences has increased over time. Specifically, we find that the costs associated to migrating between politically dissimilar counties doubled beginning in 2016, relative to the beginning in 2012 and persisted through the end of our study period in 2022.

5.2 Alignment Preferences

While the previous results tell us about the importance of partisanship differences in determining aggregate migration flows, they don't inform us about migrant preferences for moving to counties that match their own partisan values – political alignment. We provide evidence

that political alignment is an important factor in migration decisions by using the estimated party-specific destination attractiveness parameters from Equation 6, $\alpha_{j,t}^p$. Furthermore, we show that this preference for alignment differs by party and changes over time.

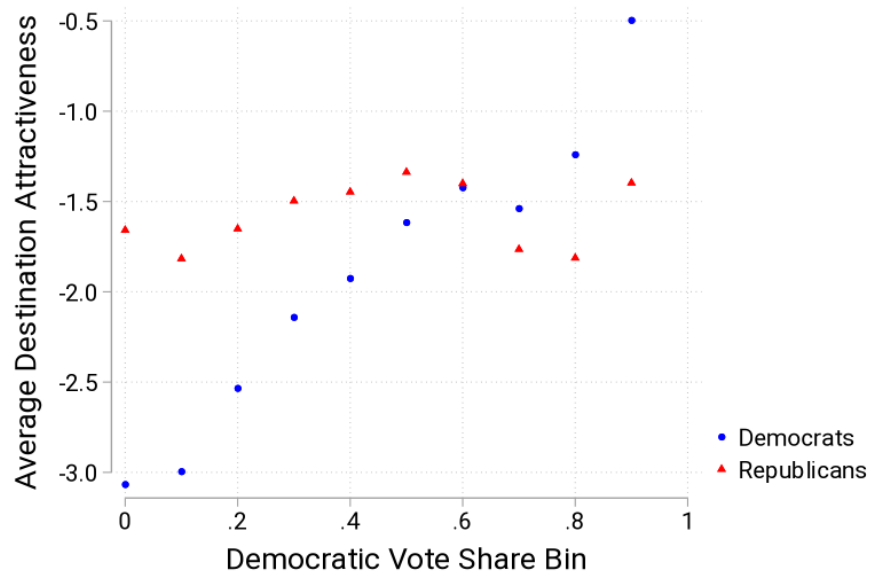
To understand how political alignment influences migration, we start by visualizing the relationship between our estimated $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ terms and the democratic vote share of county j in election period t . Figure 5 plots a bin-scatter of this relationship, with destination counties binned by their democratic vote share. This includes our estimates for every county, party, and election period combination. The figure shows that over this set of periods there is a positive relationship between a county’s democratic vote share and its attractiveness to migrants from both the Democrat and Republican parties. However, the relationship is stronger for those migrants affiliated with the Democratic party, indicated by a steeper slope. This suggests that Democratic movers have a stronger preference for counties with a higher Democratic vote share, relative to Republican movers.

However, the raw relationship between a destination’s attractiveness and its Democratic vote share might mask the effects of other county characteristics that influence its appeal to migrants. Specifically, if there are characteristics which influence both a county’s attractiveness and are correlated with the Democratic vote share, then the relationships shown in Figure 5 would be biased. For example, dense cities tend to lean more Democratic, and also are key destinations for many migrants due to their robust labor markets. As a result, density could be confounding the relationship displayed in Figure 5.

In Figure 6 we account for many of these potential confounding characteristics. Specifically, we plot a bin-scatter of the residuals from regressing $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ on a set of amenity, price, and wage variables that might otherwise affect a destination’s attractiveness. After accounting for these additional county characteristics, we now see that destinations become less attractive to Republicans on average as their Democratic vote share increases. The positive relationship between attractiveness and partisanship still holds for Democratic movers.

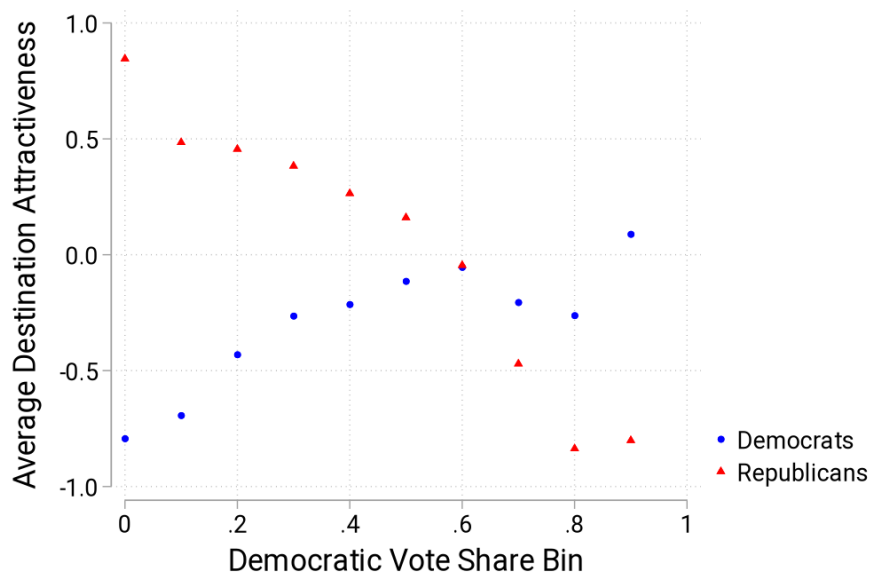
The slopes in Figure 6 are exactly the alignment preference parameters that we are

Figure 5: Average Destination Attractiveness vs. Dem. Vote Share, by Party



Notes: This figure shows the relationship between a destination's average attractiveness to movers of the Democratic and Republican party and the Democratic vote share of that destination. A positive slope suggests that movers favor more Democratic-leaning destinations. Each point is computed as the average estimated $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ term from Equation 6 by party $p \in \{\text{Democrat}, \text{Republican}\}$ across all periods t and counties j , grouped into 10 p.p. bins of the Democratic Vote share in the previous presidential election.

Figure 6: Average Residualized Destination Attractiveness vs. Dem. Vote Share, by Party



Notes: This figure shows the relationship between a destination's average residualized attractiveness to movers of the Democratic and Republican party and the Democratic vote share of that destination. The positive slope for Democratic movers suggests they favor more Democratic-leaning destinations, even after controlling for other destination characteristics that are understood to influence migration choices. The opposite is true for Republican movers. The controls include measures of county wages, prices, and amenities. For a full description of these variables, see Appendix C. To compute each point, we residualize the estimated $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ term from Equation 6 by regressing them onto these controls. We then plot the average residuals by party $p \in \{\text{Democrat, Republican}\}$ across all periods, t , and counties, j , grouped into 10 p.p. bins of the Democratic vote share in the previous presidential election.

interested in recovering. They show the extent to which Democratic and Republican movers prefer moving to destinations with Democratic vote shares that are more, or less, in line with their own political preferences, after accounting for many other characteristics that influence a destination’s attractiveness. To formalize the estimation, we run the following regression,

$$\alpha_{j,t}^p = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} + \beta_2 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Republican}^p + \xi \mathbf{X}_{j,t} + \varepsilon_{j,t}^p \quad (9)$$

where $\text{Dem. Share}_{j,t}$ is the Democratic vote share from the most recent presidential election in county j and period t , while Republican^p is an indicator variable that takes value one when party p is Republican. Therefore, β_1 captures the preference for more Democratic leaning destinations for registered Democrats and β_2 captures the differential preference for registered Republicans. Therefore, preference for political alignment is given by β_1 for Democrats and $\beta_1 + \beta_2$ for Republicans. We control for a host of amenity, price, and wage variables in $\mathbf{X}_{j,t}$ that might otherwise influence a destination’s attractiveness and be correlated with partisanship¹⁵.

The results presented in Table 4 suggest that political alignment is indeed an important factor in migration decisions. The table presents our estimated coefficients of interest from Equation 9. Column (1) shows estimates from running Equation 9 without controls, $\mathbf{X}_{j,t}$. These coefficients align with the slopes in Figure 5, where the slope for Republican movers being is sum of the coefficients on Democratic vote share and the additional effect of being Republican on the role of Democratic vote share. In Column (2) we add controls, estimating Equation 9 as written. We include these controls to account for characteristics of destinations that simultaneously affect their attractiveness to migrants and correlate with local partisanship. Therefore, the coefficients in Column (2) should capture the true effects of local partisanship on a destinations attractiveness to party-affiliated movers.

¹⁵These control variables include measures of climate and natural amenities, local consumption amenities, the population share of college graduates, population density, wages, and housing prices. We also include measures of religious presence, including the population share of non-traditional Christian denominations, which [Saiz \(2010\)](#) finds to be a useful proxy for cultural preferences regarding government regulation. For a full description of the controls, see Appendix C.

We find that Democrats prefer more democratic counties, even after controlling for a host of other destination characteristics. On the other hand, Republicans, whose preference is captured by the sum of the coefficients on Democratic vote share and Democratic vote share interacted with Republican, prefer destinations with less Democratic vote share. The specific interpretation of the estimates in Table 4 Column (2) is that a one percentage point increase in Democratic vote share of county j is associated with an 0.834% increase in the incoming flow of Democratic movers and a 1.511% decrease in the flow of incoming Republican movers, on average¹⁶

Although we control for a wide range of variables, it's possible that the specification in Column (2) of Table 4 still suffers from omitted variable bias, as discussed in Section 4.4. In Column (3) we include county fixed effects to control for all time-invariant characteristics. We also include the original time-varying controls: wages, prices, and our amenity measures. Figure A-3 in the Appendix provides a visualization of the alignment preference parameters from estimating this specification¹⁷. Column (4) additionally instruments for wages with Bartik wage shift-shares and for house prices with those same wage shift-shares interacted with local land supply constraints¹⁸.

We find significant effects of political alignment on the average attractiveness of a destination in recent times, with results that are robust to various specifications and estimation strategies. On average, both Democratic and Republican migrants prefer destinations that align with their own political views, with party-specific preferences of similar magnitudes. Specifically, we find that a one percentage point increase in a destination county's Democratic vote share is associated with a 0.834% - 1.335% increase in the incoming number of

¹⁶We compute these numbers as follows. A one percentage point increase in the Democratic vote share is associated with a $0.00834 (= 0.01 \times 0.834)$ increase in the $\alpha_{j,t}^{\text{Democrat}}$. Recall that $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ measures the average logged migration flow of into county j during time t by movers of party p . Therefore, the one percentage point increase in the Democratic vote share is associated with a 0.00834 increase in the logged migration flow of democrats into county j , or a 0.834% increase. For republican movers, the effect of a one percentage point increase in the Democratic share of county j is a $0.01511 (= 0.01 \times (0.834 - 2.345))$ change in $\alpha_{j,t}^{\text{Republican}}$.

¹⁷Figure A-3 is similar to Figure 5, but includes destination county fixed effects when residualizing the average attractiveness.

¹⁸We use land unavailability measures from Lutz and Sand (2023) and use the interaction approach from Diamond (2016).

Table 4: Mover Preferences for Democratic Vote Share, by Party

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Dem. Vote Share	2.800*** (0.074)	0.834*** (0.071)	1.335*** (0.087)	1.163*** (0.093)
Republican	1.370*** (0.039)	1.384*** (0.034)	1.412*** (0.015)	1.409*** (0.015)
Republican $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	-2.303*** (0.104)	-2.345*** (0.089)	-2.408*** (0.040)	-2.402*** (0.040)
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Destination FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
First-Stage F-Stat				41.74
R-Squared	0.129	0.372	0.916	
Observations	18,467	18,379	18,378	18,385

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: This table reports the coefficients of interest from estimating Equation 9 with various models. In Column (1) we estimate the model without any control variables using OLS. In Column (2) we add controls for amenities, housing prices, and wages. Column (3) includes county fixed effects to control for all time-invariant factors that might influence migration decisions. This specification also includes our time-varying controls for wages, prices, and amenities. Lastly, in Column (4), we estimate the same specification in Column (3) with two-staged-least-squares, instrumenting for prices and wages with Bartik wage shift-shares and local land supply constraints. In every column, the first coefficient indicates the effect of increasing a destination's Democratic vote share on its average attractiveness to Democratic migrants. Across all specifications, this is positive and significant. The third coefficient indicates the differential effect of increasing a destination's Democratic vote share on its average attractiveness to Republican migrants, relative to Democratic migrants. In every column this coefficient is negative and significant. In Columns (2) through (4) the magnitude of this coefficient is sufficiently large that there is a negative total effect of increasing the Democratic vote share of a destination on its attractiveness to Republicans. In other words, on average, Republicans dislike destinations with higher democratic vote shares, all else held constant. To see the estimated coefficients on the full set of controls, see Table B-2 in Appendix B.

Democratic migrants and a 1.073% - 1.511% decrease in the incoming number of Republican migrants.

5.3 Alignment Preferences Over Time

In this final set of results, we estimate how these partisan alignment preferences have changed over the decade from 2012 through 2022. We find that over this period political alignment preferences have grown stronger. This trend is true for both parties, although it has grown more intensely for Democratic migrants.

To estimate the preferences over time, we augment Equation 9 by fully interacting the right hand side with period dummies. This allows us to separately estimate the preferences during 2012-2015, 2016-2019, and 2020-2022 in a single regression¹⁹. Our estimated coefficients from this regression are provided in Table 5. Like before, Column (1) shows estimates from a specification without additional controls, $\mathbf{X}_{j,t}$, while Column (2) includes them. Columns (3) and (4) use destination county fixed effects to account for all time-invariant characteristics, as well as the original time-varying controls for wages, prices, and amenities. Column (4) additionally instruments for wages with Bartik wage shift-shares and for house prices with those same wage shift-shares interacted with local land supply constraints²⁰.

Our estimated coefficients, provided in Table 5, show that alignment preferences increased significantly over this period for Democrats, but less so for Republicans. For example, Column (4) shows that a one percentage point increase in the Democratic vote share of a county was associated with a 1.35% increase to the inflow of Democratic migrants during the 2012-2015 period. This grew to a 1.60% increase in the 2016-2019 period, and to a 1.75% increase in the 2020-2022 period. Column (4) also shows that a one percentage point increase in the Democratic vote share of a county was associated with a 0.77% decrease to the inflow of Republican migrants in 2012-2015, a 0.64% decrease in 2016-2019, and a 0.82%

¹⁹See Appendix E.2 for the full specification written out.

²⁰Again, we use land unavailability measures from Lutz and Sand (2023) and use the interaction approach from Diamond (2016).

Table 5: Mover Preferences over Time for Democratic Vote Share, by Party

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Dem. Vote Share	2.178*** (0.137)	0.336*** (0.126)	1.339*** (0.214)	1.352*** (0.253)
Republican $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	-1.903*** (0.194)	-1.973*** (0.163)	-2.128*** (0.073)	-2.118*** (0.072)
2016 $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	0.657*** (0.189)	0.233 (0.178)	0.354*** (0.098)	0.245*** (0.081)
Republican $\times$ 2016 $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	-0.283 (0.267)	-0.244 (0.225)	-0.111 (0.076)	-0.118 (0.075)
2020 $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	1.215*** (0.185)	0.775*** (0.178)	0.671*** (0.099)	0.398*** (0.092)
Republican $\times$ 2020 $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	-0.724*** (0.261)	-0.669*** (0.220)	-0.575*** (0.078)	-0.579*** (0.077)
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Destination FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
First-Stage F-Stat				17.70
R-Squared	0.135	0.393	0.922	
Observations	18,467	18,379	18,378	18,385

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: This table reports the coefficients of interest from estimating a version of Equation 9 that allows all parameters to vary flexibly by period. Specifically, we interact every right-hand-side variable with period dummies. The full specification is written out in Appendix E.2. Like in Table 4, Column (1) we estimate the model without any control variables using OLS, Column (2) includes county-level controls, Column (3) adds county fixed effects, and Column (4), instruments for time-varying prices and wages with Bartik wage shift-shares and local land supply constraints.

decrease in 2020-2012²¹. While migrants from both parties exhibit a preference for political alignment, the preference of Democratic migrants increased significantly from 2012 through 2022.

Figure 7 reveals that changes to alignment preferences are most salient Republican-leaning counties. The figure plots a bin-scatter of the relationship in each period between the residualized county attractiveness measures and a destination’s Democratic vote share. Slopes fitted to the points in Figure 7 Panels (a) and (b) would correspond to the total effect in each period of a destination’s Democratic vote share on its attractiveness to Democratic

²¹As above, to compute the total effect for Democrats in period $t \in \{2016, 2020\}$, we sum the coefficients on “ $t \times$ Dem. Vote Share” and the coefficient on “Dem. Vote Share”, which estimates the effect in 2012. For Republicans in period $t \in \{2016, 2020\}$, we sum the coefficients on “Republican $\times t \times$ Dem. Vote Share”, “Republican $\times$ Dem. Vote Share”, “ $t \times$ Dem. Vote Share”, and “Dem. Vote Share”.

and Republican movers, respectively, after summing up the coefficients in Table 5 Column (2) appropriately²². We can see that for counties with Democratic vote shares in $[0.1, 0.5)$ the average attractiveness for Democratic movers declined consistently over time, while the average attractiveness for Republicans increased consistently over time. For counties with Democratic vote shares in $[0.5, 1)$ the changes are a bit more ambiguous, with some small declines in average attractiveness after 2016 for both parties, followed by increases after 2020.

Our results suggest that political alignment has become an increasingly important factor to migrants over the course of 2012 through 2022. Specifically, the preference for alignment of Republican movers has been relatively stable compared to that of Democratic movers. Democrat mover preferences increased in each of our studied periods, reaching the point in 2020-2022 where a one percentage point increase in the Democratic vote share of a county was associated with a 1.11% - 2.01% increase to the inflow of Democratic migrants, depending on the exact specification. Furthermore, our results suggest the changes in alignment preferences appear to be driven by changes in attractiveness for Republican-leaning counties.

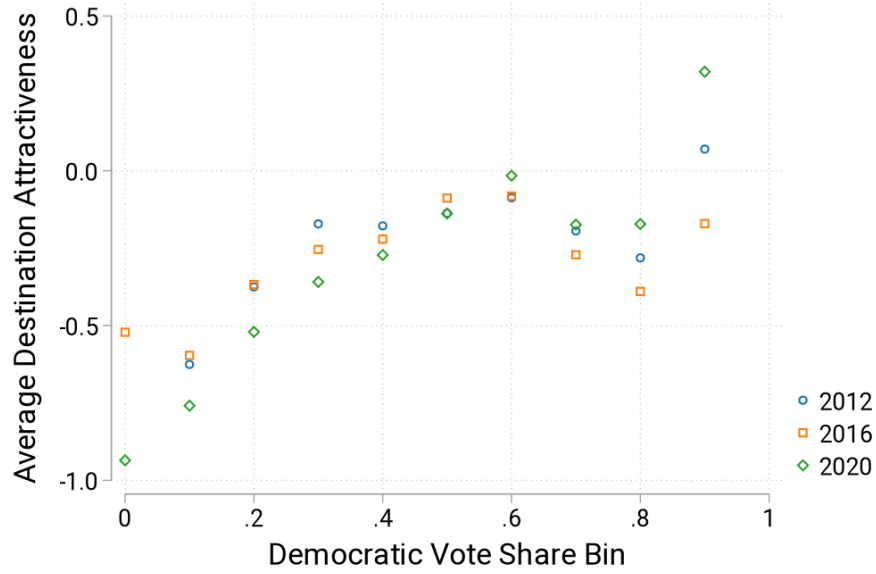
6 Implications for Partisan Segregation

We find that counties are becoming more polarizing along party lines in their attractiveness as destinations. Given our results showing that movers have strong political alignment preferences, this suggests that like-minded voters are increasingly clustering geographically. In this final section, we provide several different ways to visualize the increasing differences in county-attractiveness to migrants affiliated with different political parties.

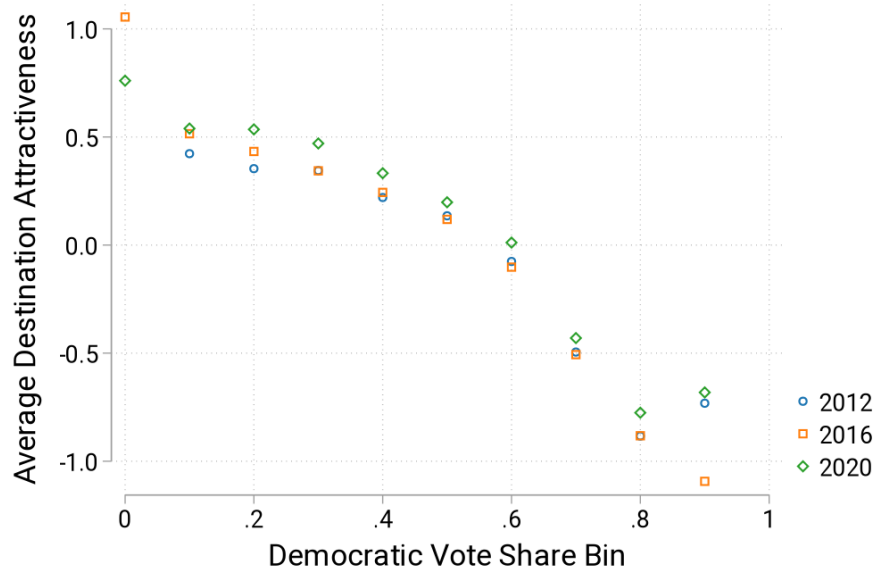
First, we show that the distribution of differences in party-specific attractiveness for counties is becoming more extreme. For every county and election period we compute the

²²Figure A-4 provides a similar visualization of the alignment preference parameters, but includes destination county fixed effects when residualizing the average attractiveness. This corresponds to the coefficients in Column (3) of Table 5.

Figure 7: Average Residualized County Attractiveness by its Dem. Vote Share, Over Time



(a) Democrats



(b) Republicans

Notes: This figure shows the relationship over time between a destination's average residualized attractiveness to movers of the Democratic and Republican party and the Democratic vote share of that destination. To compute each point, we residualize the estimated $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ term from Equation 6 by regressing them onto the same set of controls described for Figure 6. We then plot the average residuals by party $p \in \{\text{Democrat}, \text{Republican}\}$ and period t across all counties j , grouped into 10 p.p. bins of the Democratic vote share in the previous presidential election.

difference of our destination attractiveness estimates for the two parties’,

$$d_{j,t} := \alpha_{j,t}^{Dem} - \alpha_{j,t}^{Rep}$$

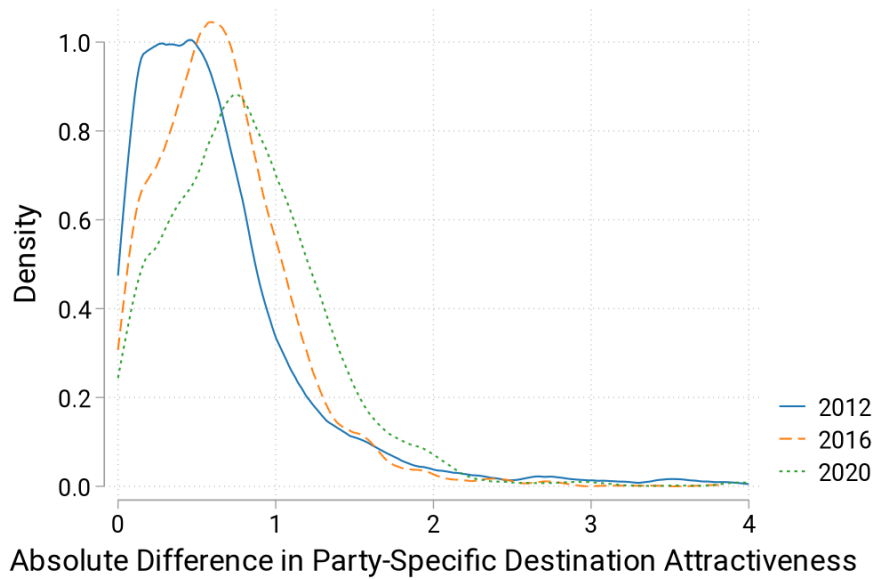
This measure captures the extent to which Democrats and Republicans differ in their preference for any given destination county. Values of $d_{j,t}$ close to zero imply migrants from the two parties find a destination similarly attractive, whereas extreme values indicate that the destination is more polarizing. We plot the distributions of $|d_{j,t}|$ for all counties by election period in Figure 8. The figure shows that this distribution is shifting to the right over time, with each subsequent period having less mass close to zero and more mass in the extreme tails. This is indicative of increasingly polarized preferences for destinations of migrants, split by political party.

Finally, Figure 9 plots these preferences on a US county map to show how the geography of these preferences has changed over time. We color counties based on their values of $d_{j,t}$ defined above. The colors for each map are set based on the quintiles of the 2012 distribution of values. Therefore, the map of the 2012 values in Panel (a) has counties evenly split into the five color buckets. In Panels (b) and (c) we see fewer counties shaded with the more neutral colors, and more shaded with the darkest blue and red. This demonstrates that relative to the 2012-2015 period, counties on average differ more intensely during the 2016-2019 and 2020-2022 periods in their attractiveness to Democratic and Republican migrants.

7 Conclusion

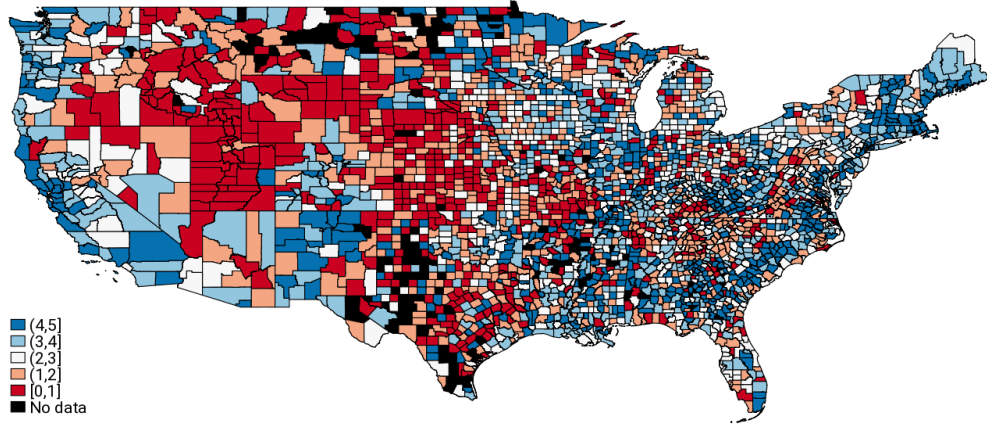
This paper provides new evidence that political alignment plays an increasingly important role in shaping internal migration patterns within the United States. We leverage detailed voter registration micro-data and model location choices in a spatial equilibrium framework in order to quantify party-specific preferences for political alignment. Our results suggest that migrants affiliated with both the Republican and Democratic parties each have strong

Figure 8: Distributions of County Differences in Attractiveness by Party Over Time

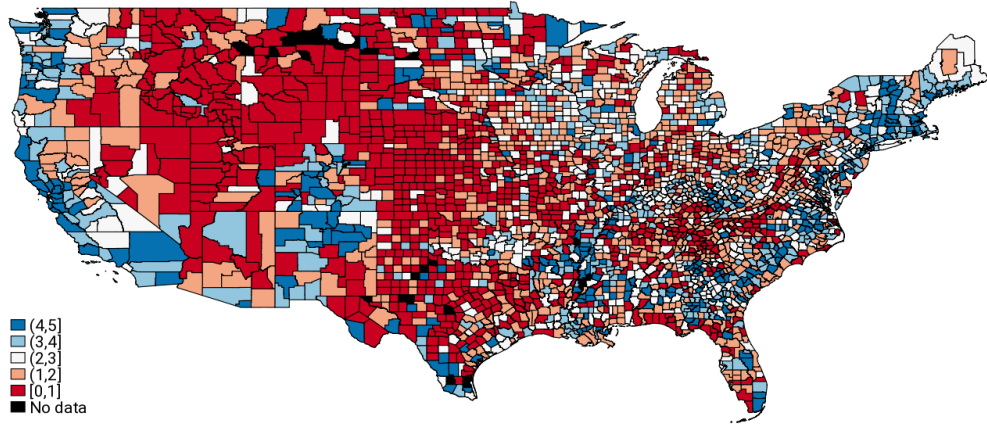


Notes: This figure plots the distribution of absolute differences in the average attractiveness of all destinations between Democratic and Republican movers. To create the figure, we compute $|\alpha_{j,t}^{\text{Democrat}} - \alpha_{j,t}^{\text{Republican}}|$ for all county destinations, j and periods t . We then use kernel density estimation to plot the density of these values for each period. Lastly, we truncated the distributions at 4 for readability (only 0.3% of observations are beyond 4 in the 2012 period, 0.1% in the 2016 period, and 0.06% in the 2020 period). The rightward shift of the distribution over time suggests that there are fewer and fewer counties that are equally attractive to Republican and Democratic movers.

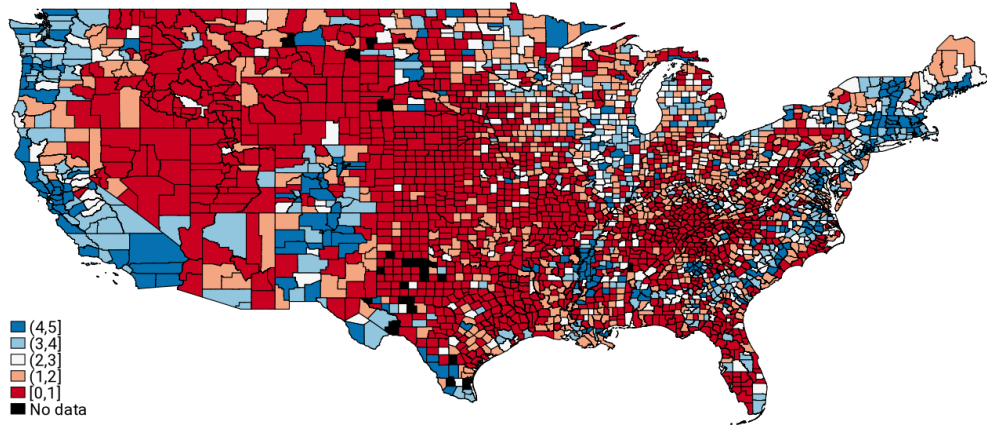
Figure 9: Map of County Differences in Attractiveness by Party Over Time



(a) 2012



(b) 2016



(c) 2020

Notes: This figure maps the differences in attractiveness of each county to Democratic and Republican movers over time. To create the figure, we compute $\alpha_{j,2012}^{\text{Democrat}} - \alpha_{j,2012}^{\text{Republican}}$ and color the 2012 map based on quintiles of this value. We then color the 2016 and 2020 maps according to the 2012 quintiles, but applying the 2016 and 2020 values.

preferences for destinations whose political composition matches their own. These results hold even after controlling for a destination's housing prices, wages, amenities, and all time-invariant characteristics, using county fixed effects. Furthermore, we find that from 2012 through 2022, this preference grew stronger, particularly for Democratic migrants. It seems that these changes are primarily driven by declines in the attractiveness of Republican-leaning counties, rather than increased appeal of Democratic-leaning ones.

The focus of this paper has been to identify the extent to which migrants prefer destinations that align with their political views. However, understanding the causes and consequences of these changing preferences is an important direction for future work. In terms of causes, it would be interesting to understand whether these changes are motivated by social considerations, policy bundles, economic factors, or something else. While we have provided some discussion on the partisan sorting implications of these preferences, it is important to understand the full set of potential consequences. For example, future research might consider how these preferences are shaping housing markets, endogenous amenities, or electoral results, through their influence on migration.

References

- Abrams, Samuel J and Morris P Fiorina, ““The big sort” that wasn’t: A skeptical reexamination,” *PS: Political Science & Politics*, 2012, *45* (2), 203–210.
- Alford, John R, Peter K Hatemi, John R Hibbing, Nicholas G Martin, and Lindon J Eaves, “The politics of mate choice,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2011, *73* (2), 362–379.
- Almagro, Milena and Tomás Domínguez-Iino, “Location Sorting and Endogenous Amenities: Evidence from Amsterdam,” Working Paper 32304, National Bureau of Economic Research April 2024.
- Besley, Timothy, Torsten Persson, and Daniel M Sturm, “Political competition, policy and growth: theory and evidence from the US,” *The Review of Economic Studies*, 2010, *77* (4), 1329–1352.
- Bishop, Bill and Robert Cushing, *The Big Sort*, Houghton Mifflin, 2008.
- Brown, Jacob R, Enrico Cantoni, Ryan Enos, Vincent Pons, and Emilie Sartre, “Causes and Extent of Increasing Partisan Segregation in the U.S. – Evidence from Migration Patterns of 212 Million Voters,” Working Paper 33422, National Bureau of Economic Research January 2025.
- , – , Sahil Chinoy, Martin Koenen, and Vincent Pons, “The Effect of Childhood Environment on Political Behavior: Evidence from Young U.S. Movers, 1992–2021,” Working Paper 31759, National Bureau of Economic Research October 2023.
- Cantoni, Enrico and Vincent Pons, “Does context outweigh individual characteristics in driving voting behavior? Evidence from relocations within the United States,” *American Economic Review*, 2022, *112* (4), 1226–1272.

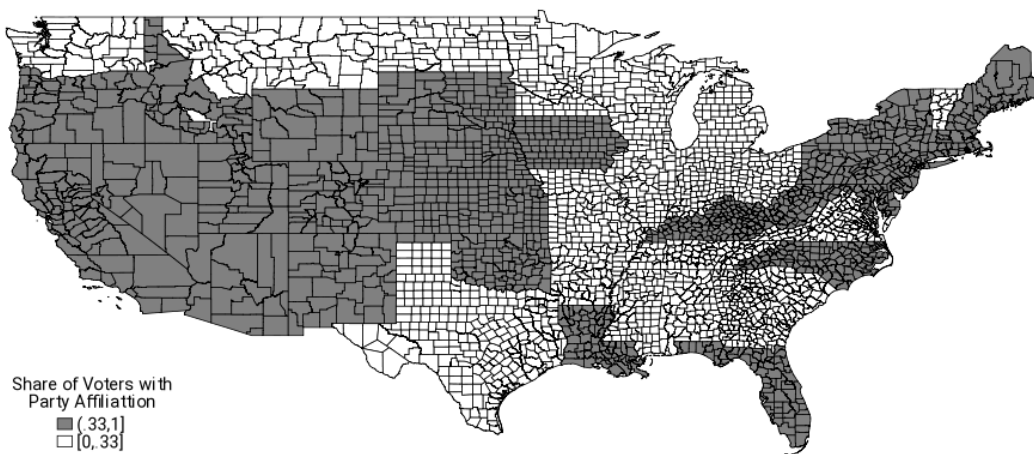
- Chinoy, Sahil and Martin Koenen**, “Political Sorting in the US Labor Market: Evidence and Explanations,” *working paper*, 2024.
- Correia, Sergio, Paulo Guimarães, and Tom Zylkin**, “Fast Poisson estimation with high-dimensional fixed effects,” *The Stata Journal*, 2020, *20* (1), 95–115.
- Davidoff, Thomas**, “Supply constraints are not valid instrumental variables for home prices because they are correlated with many demand factors,” 2015. Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=2400833>.
- Diamond, Rebecca**, “The determinants and welfare implications of US workers’ diverging location choices by skill: 1980–2000,” *American Economic Review*, 2016, *106* (3), 479–524.
- Fos, Vyacheslav, Elisabeth Kempf, and Margarita Tsoutsoura**, “The Political Polarization of Corporate America,” Working Paper 30183, National Bureau of Economic Research June 2022.
- Gentzkow, Matthew and Jesse M Shapiro**, “Ideological segregation online and offline,” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2011, *126* (4), 1799–1839.
- Glaeser, Edward L and Joseph Gyourko**, “Urban decline and durable housing,” *Journal of Political Economy*, 2005, *113* (2), 345–375.
- Hatfield, John William and Katrina Kosec**, “Federal competition and economic growth,” *Journal of Public Economics*, 2013, *97*, 144–159.
- Hopkins, Daniel J**, *The increasingly United States: How and why American political behavior nationalized*, University of Chicago Press, 2018.
- Hsieh, Chang-Tai and Enrico Moretti**, “Housing constraints and spatial misallocation,” *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics*, 2019, *11* (2), 1–39.
- Huber, Gregory A and Neil Malhotra**, “Political homophily in social relationships: Evidence from online dating behavior,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2017, *79* (1), 269–283.

- Iyengar, Shanto and Kyu S Hahn**, “Red media, blue media: Evidence of ideological selectivity in media use,” *Journal of Communication*, 2009, 59 (1), 19–39.
- , **Tobias Konitzer, and Kent Tedin**, “The home as a political fortress: Family agreement in an era of polarization,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2018, 80 (4), 1326–1338.
- Johnston, Ron, David Manley, and Kelvyn Jones**, “Spatial polarization of presidential voting in the United States, 1992–2012: The “big sort” revisited,” *Annals of the American Association of Geographers*, 2016, 106 (5), 1047–1062.
- Kinsella, Chad, Colleen McTague, and Kevin N Raleigh**, “Unmasking geographic polarization and clustering: A micro-scalar analysis of partisan voting behavior,” *Applied Geography*, 2015, 62, 404–419.
- Levendusky, Matthew S**, “Why do partisan media polarize viewers?,” *American Journal of Political Science*, 2013, 57 (3), 611–623.
- Lutz, Chandler and Ben Sand**, “Highly disaggregated land unavailability,” 2023. Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=3478900>.
- MIT Election Data and Science Lab**, “County Presidential Election Returns 2000-2020,” 2018. Available at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/VOQCHQ>.
- Mummolo, Jonathan and Clayton Nall**, “Why partisans do not sort: The constraints on political segregation,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2017, 79 (1), 45–59.
- Myers, Adam S**, “Secular geographical polarization in the American South: The case of Texas, 1996–2010,” *Electoral Studies*, 2013, 32 (1), 48–62.
- Pew Research Center**, “Political Polarization in the American Public,” 2014. Available at <https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2014/06/12/political-polarization-in-the-american-public/>.

- Prior, Markus**, *Post-broadcast democracy: How media choice increases inequality in political involvement and polarizes elections*, Cambridge University Press, 2007.
- Roback, Jennifer**, “Wages, rents, and the quality of life,” *Journal of political Economy*, 1982, *90* (6), 1257–1278.
- Rosen, Harvey S**, “Housing decisions and the US income tax: An econometric analysis,” *Journal of Public Economics*, 1979, *11* (1), 1–23.
- Saiz, Albert**, “The geographic determinants of housing supply,” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2010, *125* (3), 1253–1296.
- Stansel, Dean**, “Local decentralization and local economic growth: A cross-sectional examination of US metropolitan areas,” *Journal of Urban Economics*, 2005, *57* (1), 55–72.
- Sunstein, Cass**, *Designing Democracy: What Constitutions Do*, Oxford University Press, 2001.
- Sussell, Jesse**, “New support for the big sort hypothesis: an assessment of partisan geographic sorting in California, 1992–2010,” *PS: Political Science & Politics*, 2013, *46* (4), 768–773.
- Tam Cho, Wendy K, James G Gimpel, and Iris S Hui**, “Voter migration and the geographic sorting of the American electorate,” *Annals of the Association of American Geographers*, 2013, *103* (4), 856–870.
- Tiebout, Charles M**, “A pure theory of local expenditures,” *Journal of Political Economy*, 1956, *64* (5), 416–424.

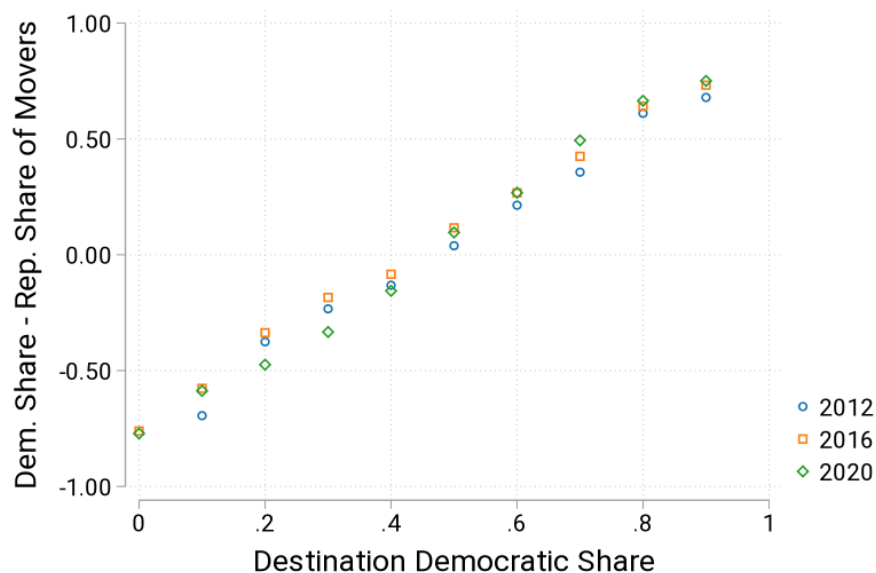
A Appendix: Figures

Figure A-1: Party Affiliation by County



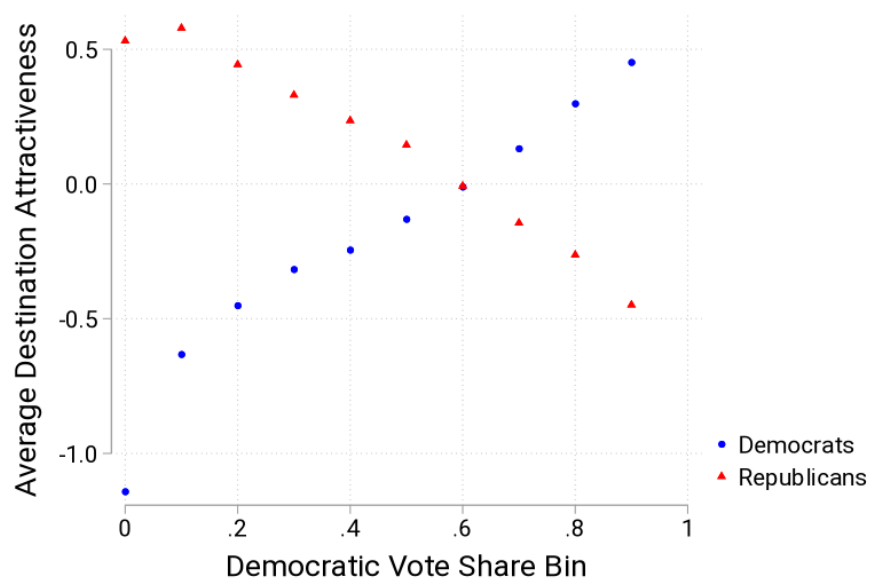
Notes: This figure shows counties where more than one third of registered voters were affiliated with a party on their registration from 2012 through 2015. Typically, states with a party-specific primary system for presidential elections require voters to be affiliated with a party in order to participate in their party's primary. The following states do not require voters to list an affiliation when registering, for the most part due to a lack of presidential primaries: AL, AR, GA, HI, IL, IN, MI, MN, MO, MS, MT, ND, OH, SC, TN, TX, VA, VT, WA, and WI. Despite this, we will still be able to identify party preferences for counties in these states due to movers who move in from states which do require party affiliation for primary participation.

Figure A-2: Difference in Party Share of Movers by Destination Democratic Share and Year



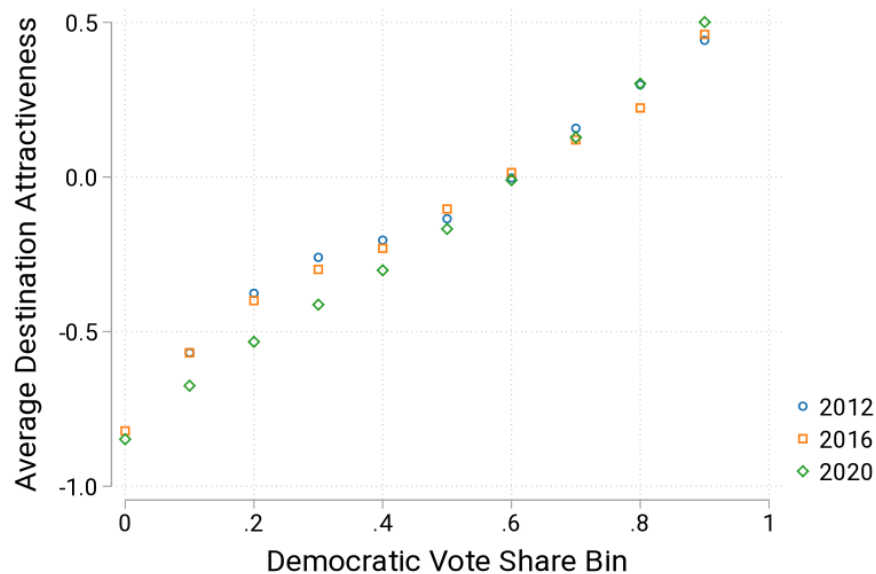
Notes: This figure shows the difference in the shares of Democratic and Republican movers out of all party-affiliated movers into counties of a given binned Democratic vote share in each period. For example, the green diamond at the 0.7 value for destination Democratic vote share indicates that party-affiliated movers into counties with 70-80% Democratic vote shares were 50 percentage points more likely to be Democrats than Republicans. Overall, we see a positive relationship between the share of Democratic movers and the Democratic vote share of a destination. There are slight changes over time, namely increases in the share of Democrats moving into Democratic-leaning counties and increases in the share of Republicans moving into Republican-leaning counties.

Figure A-3: Average Residualized Destination Attractiveness vs. Dem. Vote Share, by Party (Destination Fixed Effect Specification)

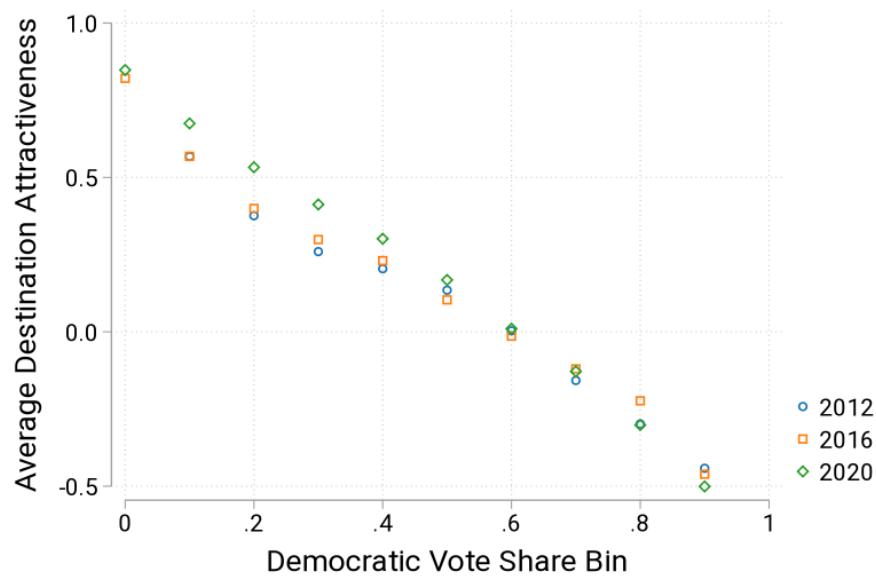


Notes: This figure shows the relationship between a destination's average residualized attractiveness to movers of the Democratic and Republican party and the Democratic vote share of that destination. We compute each point similarly to those in Figure 6, though we additionally include destination fixed effects when residualizing the estimated $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ terms in this version. The relationships observed in Figure 6 are present in this figure as well.

Figure A-4: Average Residualized County Attractiveness by its Dem. Vote Share, Over Time (Destination Fixed Effect Specification)



(a) Democrats



(b) Republicans

Notes: This figure shows the relationship over time between a destination's average residualized attractiveness to movers of the Democratic and Republican party and the Democratic vote share of that destination. We compute each point similarly to those in Figure 7, though we additionally include destination fixed effects when residualizing the estimated $\alpha_{j,t}^p$ terms in this version. We see the same relationships as in Figure 7. Specifically, we see that changes in the preferences for alignment seem to be driven by changes in attractiveness to Republican-leaning counties, for both Democratic and Republican movers.

B Appendix: Tables

Table B-1: Moving Costs Breakdown

	(1)
Dem. Vote Share Diff.	-1.200*** (0.006)
Diff. in Industry Structure	0.888*** (0.010)
Diff. in Ethnic Composition (2000)	-0.194*** (0.006)
Log Distance	-1.024*** (0.003)
Diff. State	-3.859*** (0.014)
Diff State $\times$ Log Distance	0.607*** (0.003)
Diff. in Urban Status	0.318*** (0.002)
Diff. in College Share (2000)	-2.559*** (0.010)
Diff. in Amenities (1st PC)	0.111*** (0.002)
Diff. in Amenities (2nd PC)	0.132*** (0.002)
Diff. in Water Surface	-0.230*** (0.005)
Diff. in Density	-0.000*** (0.000)
Diff. in Church Density	-0.047*** (0.001)
Diff. in Non-trad. Christian Share	0.001 (0.004)
Diff. in Jan. Temp.	0.008*** (0.000)
Constant	3.978*** (0.013)
R-Squared	0.310
Observations	3,376,124

* p < 0.10, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Notes: This table reports our all estimated coefficients from estimating Equation 8 with OLS on our panel of party-specific county-to-county migration flows. See Appendix C for a description of the full set of controls.

Table B-2: Mover Preferences for Democratic Vote Share, by Party (All Controls)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Dem. Vote Share	2.800*** (0.074)	0.834*** (0.071)	1.335*** (0.087)	1.163*** (0.093)
Republican	1.370*** (0.039)	1.384*** (0.034)	1.412*** (0.015)	1.409*** (0.015)
Republican $\times$ Dem. Vote Share	-2.303*** (0.104)	-2.345*** (0.089)	-2.408*** (0.040)	-2.402*** (0.040)
Housing Price Index		0.154*** (0.024)	0.317*** (0.059)	-0.374 (0.503)
Logged Wages		0.069* (0.041)	-0.195** (0.078)	0.287 (0.556)
Amenities (1st PC)		-0.125*** (0.012)	0.122*** (0.026)	0.075*** (0.026)
Amenities (2nd PC)		0.025* (0.015)	-0.047** (0.023)	-0.039 (0.024)
Mean Jan. Temp.		0.000 (0.001)		
Non-trad. Christian Share		-0.695*** (0.034)		
Church Density		-0.048*** (0.008)		
Density		0.000*** (0.000)		
Water Surface		-0.394*** (0.063)		
College Share (2000)		0.019*** (0.001)		
Urban-Rural Code		-0.121*** (0.007)		
Metropolitan Area		0.183*** (0.030)		
Urban Area		0.104*** (0.031)		
Constant	-3.075*** (0.028)	-4.446*** (0.451)	-4.242*** (0.510)	
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Destination FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
First-Stage F-Stat				41.74
R-Squared	0.129	0.372	0.916	0.499
Observations	18,467	18,379	18,378	18,385

* p < 0.10, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Notes: This table reports all coefficients from estimating Equation 9 with various models. The specifications match those in Table 4. See Appendix C for descriptions of the variables.

C Appendix: Description of Additional Data

The following section describes the supplemental data sources used in the analysis. Ultimately, we build a panel dataset with origin-destination county pairs as our unit of observation and presidential election years as our time variable. Our key variables, described in Section 2, are measures of party-specific migration between pairs of counties and measures of county-level political preferences. The following data supplements these main variables, allowing us to control for additional characteristics that influence migration.

We measure many county characteristics using variables from the 2000 Census. We control for natural amenities using the average January temperature and the water share of the county’s geographic area. We control for the average education level of counties using the population share of college graduates. We also control for county population density and whether the county is urban or rural.

Constructed Control Variables

Religious Adherence

We use data on county-level religious membership, adherence, and the number of churches from the National Council of Churches of Christ in the U.S.A. (NCCC). This survey data was collected in 1971. We follow [Saiz \(2010\)](#) and [Davidoff \(2015\)](#) in defining non-traditional denominations as the complement of: Catholic, United Church of Christ, American Baptist, Presbyterian, Methodist, Lutheran, and Episcopal. We additionally exclude the Christian Church (Disciples of Christ) from the set of non-traditional Christians, which also considers itself a mainline Protestant denomination. We calculate any shares based on "adherence" rather than membership. We drop 26 counties from this data in which the number of recorded adherents exceeds the recorded total population.

Table C-1: List of Amenity Industries

NAICS Code	NAICS Industry Name
4451	Grocery Stores
512131	Motion Picture Theaters
722	Food Services and Drinking Places
448	Clothing and Accessory Stores
8123	Dry Cleaners
7121	Museums, Historical Sites, and Similar Institutions
711211	Sports Teams
487	Scenic and Sightseeing Transportation
453110	Florists

Amenities

We follow [Diamond \(2016\)](#) and [Almagro and Domínguez-Iino \(2024\)](#) by creating a measure of local amenities using the count of establishments in certain key industries which provide leisure services to tourists and residents. Together, these industries proxy for the attractiveness of local endogenous amenities.

Specifically, our measure of amenities is based on annual establishment counts of key amenity industries, from the County Business Patterns dataset. Table C-1 lists the NAICS industries that we consider to be amenity industries. We use principal component analysis on the establishment counts in each of the amenity industries in order to reduce the dimensionality of our amenity measure into just its first two principal components. Formally, we use components z_1 and z_2 from $z = [z_1, z_2, \dots, z_K]$, where $z = xu$ such that u maximizes the variance of the elements of z and satisfies the restriction $u'u = 1$. Here, $x = [x_1, x_2, \dots, x_K]$ is a matrix with column x_k giving the county establishment counts in industry $k \in K$. K is the set of amenity industries listed in Table C-1.

Additional Measures of County Differences

We also control for differences in industrial and ethnic composition, as well as physical distances, in our migration cost regressions. Industry structure differences are computed as the vector distance in 2-digit NAICS industry employment shares between pairs of counties.

For our measure of a county’s ethnic composition, we rely on 2000 Census county population by race and ethnicity. To measure the difference in ethnic composition for each pair of counties, we take the L2 norm of ethnic distance between every pair of counties,

$$\sqrt{\sum_n x_n^2}$$

where x_n is the absolute difference in the population share of racial category n between two counties, and $n \in \{\text{non-Hispanic White, Black, Native American, Asian, Hispanic, other or multiple races}\}$.

Lastly, we include controls for the physical distance between counties. We also allow migration costs between a pair of counties to depend on whether they are in the same state or not, as well as the interaction between this and physical distance.

D Appendix: Migration Panel Construction

This section outlines the data preparation process for creating out panel of party-specific county-to-county migration flows. In the registration process, voters are given a unique voter identification number, which they keep even after updating their address to a new location, as long as it is within the same state. Since voter registration is a state-managed process, voters who move across state lines are given a new identification number when they re-register. We therefore use Statara’s person-level identifier that tracks people over time, even across inter-state moves. We then identify movers using changes in address listed on their voter registration. Lastly, we collapse our data into three periods, computing total migration in 2012-2015, 2016-2019, and 2020-2022

De-duplicating Voters

Within the Statara data, there is a third-party identifier, *Exacttrack ID*, which can be used to track people across states and over time. This identifier occasionally contains duplicate entries, most often with children who share a name with their parent and were recorded at the same address. We de-duplicate the *Exacttrack ID* by creating a new identifier that combines the *Exacttrack ID* with a person’s birth year.

Identifying Movers

One challenge with this data is that there are occasionally multiple addresses listed for a given individual, making it hard to know exactly which address a person lives in. These addresses typically come from merged in third party data that Statara adds to the voter registration data. Different addresses are likely due to moves that are recorded by data vendors before they are recorded in the registration data. To be conservative, we consider someone to have moved if any of the addresses listed in a given year were not listed in either of the previous two years (as long as those two years had at least one address listed). Given that our data begins in 2012, we are therefore able to first identify movers in 2014. This will

not capture for moves back and forth between two properties that are continually reported for a given person. We also restrict our attention inter-county moves.

Assigning Current Counties

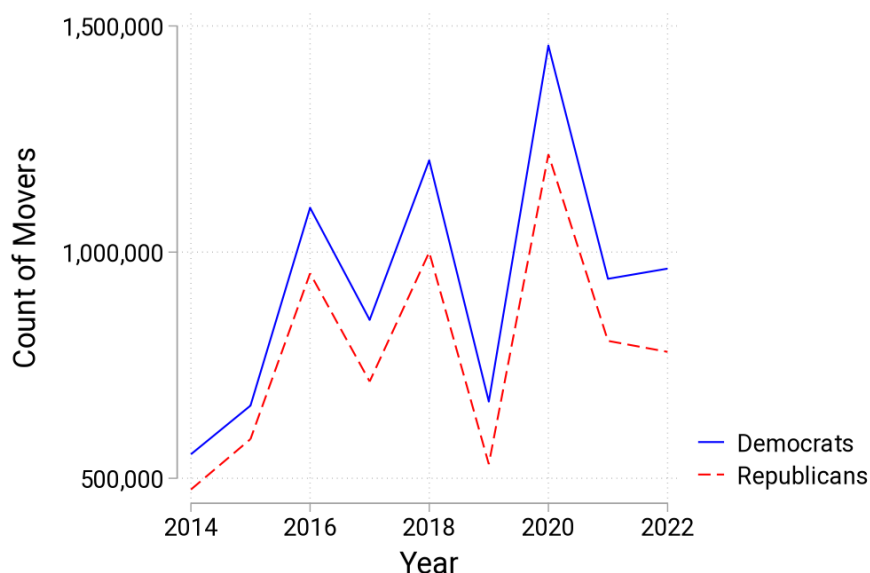
We use the following logic to assign an individuals to a county in each year:

1. For the first observation of a person:
 - If all listed addresses are in the same county, we assign that county..
 - For the remaining individuals, assign the county which matches the listed registration
2. For subsequent observations that are flagged as a county move:
 - If only one listed county is flagged as new, then assign that county
 - We drop observations where multiple counties are flagged as new, which accounts for less than 0.3% of moves.
3. For subsequent observations that are not flagged as a county move we assign the county from the previous year.

Assigning Party Affiliation

We pull party affiliation from the voter registration information. If a person is registered in multiple counties, then we use the one from their assigned county (see **Assigning Current Counties** above). There are some states which do not record party affiliation (see Figure [A-1](#)). For people in these states, we use their last previously listed affiliation. As a result, we will have party affiliation information for those living in these states who we observe moving from affiliation-recording states. We never observe party affiliation for individuals who only ever live states that do not record party affiliation.

Figure D-1: Annual Mover Count, by Party



Notes: This figure shows the annual number of individuals who move between counties, by party affiliation. Spikes in even years are likely attributed to individuals re-registering to vote with their new address in major election years. As a result, we aggregate migration across post-election periods, rather than using annual counts. The relatively low level of migration in 2014 is likely a feature of our migration detection algorithm.

Aggregation

We aggregate the individual level into annual county-to-county migration flows by party. We group anyone affiliated with the Democratic, Green, or Working Families parties as Democrats. We group anyone affiliated with the Conservative or Republican parties as Republicans.

Figure D-1 shows the number of movers each year by party affiliation. The figure shows clear spikes in migration every two years, aligning with major election years. We suspect this is because those who migrate in the between years don't update their registration until right before a major election. Therefore it might be hard to infer the exact year in which people move. Because of this, we collapse the annual county migration flows into three periods: 2012-2015, 2016-2019, and 2020-2022.

E Appendix: Regression Specifications by Period

E.1 Time Varying Migration Costs Specification

The following regression equation is used to estimate the costs over time associated with migrating between counties with differences in their Democratic vote shares:

$$\begin{aligned}\gamma_{ij,t} = & \alpha_0 + \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \text{Period}_t^{2020} + \alpha_1 |\text{Dem. Share}_{i,t} - \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t}| \\ & + \alpha_2 |\text{Dem. Share}_{i,t} - \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t}| \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} \\ & + \alpha_3 |\text{Dem. Share}_{i,t} - \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t}| \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} \\ & + \alpha_4 \mathbf{X}_{ij,t} + \alpha_5 \mathbf{X}_{ij,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \alpha_6 \mathbf{X}_{ij,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} \\ & + \alpha_7 \mathbf{X}_{ij} + \alpha_8 \mathbf{X}_{ij} \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \alpha_9 \mathbf{X}_{ij} \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} + \varepsilon_{ij,t}\end{aligned}\tag{10}$$

where Period_t^s , for $s \in \{2016, 2020\}$, are dummy variables that take value 1 when $t = s$ and 0 otherwise. The estimation results are provided and discussed in Section 5.1.

E.2 Time Varying Alignment Preferences Specification

The following regression equation is used to estimate the party-specific political alignment preferences over time:

$$\begin{aligned}\alpha_{j,t}^p = & \beta_0 + \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \text{Period}_t^{2020} + \beta_1 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} + \beta_2 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} \\ & + \beta_3 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} + \beta_4 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Republican}^p \\ & + \beta_5 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Republican}^p \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} \\ & + \beta_6 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Republican}^p \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} \\ & + \xi_1 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} + \xi_2 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \xi_3 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} + \varepsilon_{j,t}^p\end{aligned}\tag{11}$$

where Period_t^s , for $s \in \{2016, 2020\}$, are dummy variables that take value 1 when $t = s$ and 0 otherwise. The estimation results are provided and discussed in Section 5.3.

F Appendix: Robustness Using Differences in Party-Specific Attractiveness

In this robustness exercise we estimate the effect of Democratic vote share on the difference in a county's attractiveness to Democrats and Republicans. The differencing of the party-specific attractiveness parameters should control for all destination by election period factors that do not differ by migrants of the two parties. Specifically, we estimate the following equation:

$$d_{j,t} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} + \xi_1 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} + \varepsilon_{j,t} \quad (12)$$

where $d_{j,t} := \alpha_{j,t}^{Dem} - \alpha_{j,t}^{Rep}$, $\text{Dem. Share}_{j,t}$ is the Democratic vote share of county j , and $\mathbf{X}_{j,t}$ is our standard set of controls. In Column (3) we interact all independent variables with period dummy variables to estimate the differences over time. In this case, we estimate the following:

$$\begin{aligned} d_{j,t} = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \\ & + \beta_2 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \beta_3 \text{Dem. Share}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} \\ & + \xi_1 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} + \xi_2 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2016} + \xi_3 \mathbf{X}_{j,t} \times \text{Period}_t^{2020} + \varepsilon_{j,t} \end{aligned} \quad (13)$$

where Period_t^s , for $s \in \{2016, 2020\}$, are dummy variables that take value 1 when $t = s$ and 0 otherwise.

Table F-1 reports the results of estimating these equations with our panel of county-to-county migration flows by party. The results align with our findings in Sections 5.2 and 5.3. The estimated coefficient in Column (2) shows that counties with a higher Democratic vote share are more attractive destinations for Democratic movers, relative to Republican movers. Column (3) shows that the relative difference in attractiveness has grown over our study period. One downside of this specification is that we cannot separately estimate the party-specific preferences.

Table F-1: Difference in Partisan Mover Preferences for Democratic Vote Share

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Dem. Vote Share	5.072*** (0.125)	2.407*** (0.121)	1.693*** (0.210)
2016×Dem. Vote Share			0.555* (0.304)
2020×Dem. Vote Share			1.213*** (0.308)
Controls	No	Yes	Yes
R-Squared	0.149	0.476	0.493
Observations	9,345	9,295	9,295

* p< 0.10, ** p< 0.05, *** p< 0.01

Notes: This table reports coefficients from estimating Equations 12 and 13, which use $\alpha_{j,t}^{\text{Dem}} - \alpha_{j,t}^{\text{Rep}}$ as the dependent variable. This measures the difference in average attractiveness of destination j to Democratic and Republican movers during period t . As a result, it should difference out any time varying factors that movers form each party value equally. Column (1) shows the results from estimating the model with no controls, Column (2) adds county-level controls, and Column (3) estimates a version of the model that allows all variables to vary flexibly over time.